

Experiment Report: Mitigating Cognitive Debt in AI-Assisted Development

Report generated from the analysis of Pull Requests
from the `tictactoe_experiment`

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Contents

1	Introduction	4
2	Experimental Methodology	4
2.1	Context and Research Questions	5
2.2	Study Design	5
2.3	Procedure	6
2.4	Data Collection and Analysis	6
3	Participants	7
4	Qualitative Analysis by Participant	8
4.1	PR 1 — Participant 01	8
4.2	PR 2 — Participant 02	8
4.3	PR 3 — Participant 03	8
4.4	PR 4 — Participant 04	9
4.5	PR 5 — Participant 05	9
4.6	PR 6 — Participant 06	9
4.7	PR 7 — Participant 07	9
4.8	PR 9 — Participant 09	9
4.9	PR 11 — Participant 11	9
4.10	PR 12 — Participant 12	10
4.11	PR 13 — Participant 13	10
4.12	PR 14 — Participant 14	10
4.13	PR 15 — Participant 15	10
4.14	PR 16 — Participant 16	10
4.15	PR 17 — Participant 17	11
4.16	PR 18 — Participant 18	11
4.17	PR 19 — Participant 19	11
4.18	PR 20 — Participant 20	11
4.19	PR 21 — Participant 21	11
4.20	PR 22 — Participant 22	12
4.21	PR 23 — Participant 23	12
4.22	PR 24 — Participant 24	12

4.23	PR 25 — Participant 25	12
4.24	PR 26 — Participant 26	12
4.25	PR 27 — Participant 27	13
4.26	PR 28 — Participant 28	13
4.27	PR 29 — Participant 29	13
4.28	PR 30 — Participant 30	13
4.29	PR 31 — Participant 31	13
4.30	PR 32 — Participant 32	14
4.31	PR 33 — Participant 33	14
4.32	PR 34 — Participant 34	14
5	Comparative Analysis — Task 1 (Pipeline) vs. Task 2 (Without Pipeline)	14
5.1	Architectural Approaches	15
5.2	Individual Scores by Task	15
5.2.1	Scoring Rubric (0–100 per task)	15
5.3	Statistical Significance and Effect Size	16
5.3.1	Wilcoxon signed-rank test	16
5.3.2	Effect sizes	17
5.3.3	Sensitivity analysis: alternative Mastery Score weightings	17
5.4	Task Complexity Equivalence	17
5.5	Artifact Quality: Task 1 vs. Task 2	18
5.6	Cognitive Debt Indicators	18
5.6.1	Debugging confidence	18
5.6.2	Module explanation	19
5.6.3	Specific technical gaps revealed by the Socratic debate	20
5.6.4	Sustainability without AI	21
5.6.5	Engagement with Copilot	21
5.7	Observed Quantitative Patterns	22
6	Socratic Review Analysis	23
6.1	Socratic vs. Missing Socratic: Correlation with Quality	23
6.2	Patterns in Socratic Answers	23
6.2.1	Participant profile and correlation with score	23
6.2.2	Model diversity: impact and within-subjects cancellation	24
6.2.3	Consistent comparative reflections	25
6.2.4	Emerging technical finding	25
6.3	PR 1 — Participant 01 (Socratic)	25
6.4	PR 2 — Participant 02 (Socratic)	26
6.5	PR 3 — Participant 03 (Socratic)	26
6.6	PR 4 — Participant 04 (Socratic)	27
6.7	PR 5 — Participant 05 (Missing Socratic)	27
6.8	PR 6 — Participant 06 (Socratic)	28
6.9	PR 7 — Participant 07 (Socratic)	28
6.10	PR 9 — Participant 09 (Rejected)	29
6.11	PR 11 — Participant 11 (Rejected)	29
6.12	PR 12 — Participant 12 (Socratic)	29
6.13	PR 13 — Participant 13 (Socratic)	30
6.14	PR 14 — Participant 14 (Socratic)	30
6.15	PR 15 — Participant 15 (Rejected)	30

6.16	PR 16 — Participant 16 (Missing Socratic)	31
6.17	PR 17 — Participant 17 (Socratic)	32
6.18	PR 18 — Participant 18 (Socratic)	32
6.19	PR 19 — Participant 19 (Rejected)	33
6.20	PR 20 — Participant 20 (Socratic)	33
6.21	PR 21 — Participant 21 (Socratic)	33
6.22	PR 22 — Participant 22 (Missing Socratic)	40
6.23	PR 23 — Participant 23 (Missing Socratic)	40
6.24	PR 24 — Participant 24 (Missing Socratic)	40
6.25	PR 25 — Participant 25 (Socratic)	41
6.26	PR 26 — Participant 26 (Missing Socratic)	41
6.27	PR 27 — Participant 27 (Missing Socratic)	41
6.28	PR 28 — Participant 28 (Socratic)	42
6.29	PR 29 — Participant 29 (Missing Socratic)	46
6.30	PR 30 — Participant 30 (Socratic)	46
6.31	PR 31 — Participant 31 (Socratic)	50
6.32	PR 32 — Participant 32 (Socratic)	61
6.33	PR 33 — Participant 33 (Socratic)	63
6.34	PR 34 — Participant 34 (Socratic)	72
7	Limitations and Discussion	81
7.1	Threats to Validity	81
7.1.1	Internal validity	81
7.1.2	External validity	81
7.2	Incomplete data	82
7.3	Discussion	82
8	Conclusion	83

1 Introduction

This report documents the results of an educational experiment conducted with software engineering students, grounded in the theoretical framework proposed in the paper “*Putting Brains Back in the Loop: A Mastery-Aware Pipeline for LLM-Assisted Software Development*”. The experiment empirically investigates the paper’s central hypothesis: that the removal of friction provided by AI assistants generates **Cognitive Debt** — a knowledge deficit resulting from excessive delegation of reasoning to the language model — and that the reintroduction of **desirable difficulty** through a structured pipeline can mitigate this effect.

The concept of **Cognitive Bypass** describes the phenomenon in which the developer acts as a passive reviewer rather than an active creator, approving AI-generated code without synthesizing the underlying logic. This behavior, analogous to the automation bias (*Automation Bias*) described by Perry et al., represents a significant risk to the formation of robust mental models.

The **Mastery-Aware Pipeline** proposes a two-stage solution:

1. **Formal Specification** — the developer must manually fill in the `TODO.md` artifact before any code is generated, articulating requirements, edge cases and success criteria.
2. **Proof of Mastery** — after AI-assisted implementation, the developer must produce the `REACT0.md` artifact demonstrating understanding of the solution through the REACTO protocol (**R**epeat, **E**xamples, **A**pproach, **C**ode, **T**est, **O**ptimize).

The experiment used a web Tic-Tac-Toe game as the domain, with two tasks of comparable complexity:

- **Task 1** (WITH pipeline): Replace the X and O symbols with emojis (cat and dog), with the Mastery-Aware pipeline activated (`pipeline.sh ON`).
- **Task 2** (WITHOUT pipeline): Implement a persistent win scoreboard, with the pipeline deactivated (`pipeline.sh OFF`), allowing free interaction with Copilot.

The task order was a deliberate methodological decision: the instrumented task (Task 1) was performed first to give the free-delegation task (Task 2) the advantage of being the more recent and fresh experience in the student’s memory at the time of the Socratic review. The independent variable is therefore the presence or absence of the structured pipeline. At the end of both tasks, the **Socratic Reviewer** conducts the reflective interview to assess the student’s mastery of the code produced in each task.

2 Experimental Methodology

This section details the empirical methodology employed to investigate the impact of Socratic reasoning models on cognitive and intent debt during software development tasks, focusing on the cognitive processes involved in AI assisted development.

2.1 Context and Research Questions

The study investigates how prompting strategies—specifically the presence or absence of Socratic reasoning (*Ask, Then Think* [?])—affect developer performance and cognitive load. The experiment is contextualized within the broader discussion of cognitive and intent debt [?]. We seek to answer the following research questions:

- **RQ1:** To what extent can the existence of cognitive debt be systematically detected and quantitatively measured within an AI-assisted development workflow?
- **RQ2:** What is the effect of introducing desirable friction—such as structured constraints and Socratic interactions—as a mechanism to mitigate cognitive debt?

2.2 Study Design

We conducted a controlled experiment with multiple participants completing assigned programming tasks within a self-contained HTML and JavaScript Tic-Tac-Toe application. The experiment was designed so everybody could run it without any difficulties: it could be run directly from the browser, and even the automated tests did not depend on any additional tool or package installation. To illustrate the expected progression, Figure 1 shows the initial version of the application, the test execution, and the final version representing the outcome of the completed tasks.

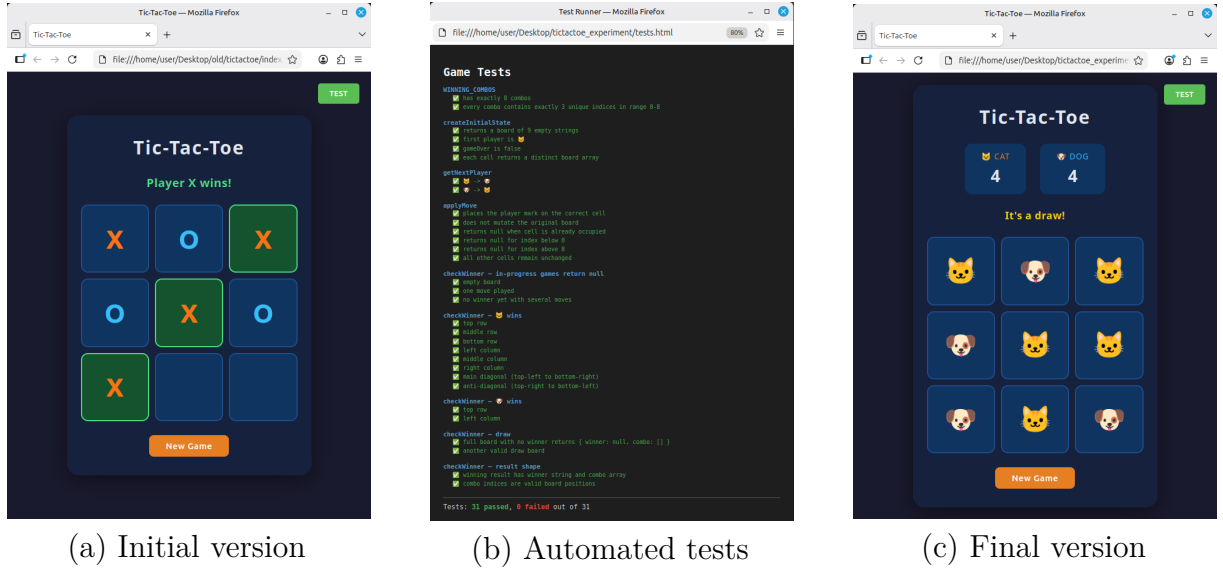


Figure 1: Progression of the Tic-Tac-Toe application during the experiment.

The core interaction model was intended to be the *Socratic* protocol (“ask, then think”) for all participants, where the assistant prompts the user for clarification before generating solutions. However, due to model errors or participants failing to follow instructions, a subset of submissions lacked this interactive transcript. These cases are categorized as *Missing Socratic* and were discarded from the final comparative analysis, because they made it impossible to accurately compare the controlled pipeline scenario with the baseline scenario.

The dependent variables include:

1. **Submission Acceptance Status:** Pull Requests are evaluated for inclusion based on strict criteria: the presence of explicit participant consent and a complete Socratic review transcript covering both experimental tasks.
2. **Cognitive Debt (Mastery Score):** A quantitative assessment (0–100 scale) of the participant’s mental model and understanding of the generated code, measured separately for Task 1 and Task 2. The score comprises three dimensions:
 - *Module Explanation* (0–45): Ability to accurately describe interactions between components without referring to the code.
 - *Socratic Debate* (0–35): Quality, depth, and accuracy of answers to technical questions posed by the agent.
 - *Design Justification* (0–20): Understanding and articulation of the architectural rationale behind the implemented solution.

The delta between the Task 2 score and the Task 1 score serves as the primary measure of the *cognitive debt shift*.

2.3 Procedure

The experiment is divided into two sequential tasks within a Tic-Tac-Toe web application, controlled by the `pipeline.sh` script and dynamically loaded `.github` instructions for agents and skills.

1. **Task 1 (Replacing Symbols with Emojis):** Participants are tasked with replacing the traditional ‘X’ and ‘O’ symbols with cat and dog emojis. During this phase, the pipeline is active (`pipeline.sh ON`), monitoring and controlling the experiment to enforce desirable friction and structured constraints, based on the “Putting Brains Back in the Loop” approach. Specifically, the agent requires mandatory reading of `TODO.md`, refuses to write to protected artifacts (`TODO.md` and `REACTO.md`), requests the user update `REPORT.md`, and enforces incremental verification step-by-step.
2. **Task 2 (Scoreboard Implementation):** Participants must implement a basic scoreboard mechanism to track wins for both the cat and dog players. Before starting this task, the `pipeline.sh` script is disabled (`pipeline.sh OFF`), deactivating the constraints. This transitions the environment into the varied scenarios (e.g., standard interaction without forced guidelines) that are ultimately compared for each Pull Request. Participants generate the code under these realistic altered conditions without required documentation or agent guardrails.

Throughout the tasks, the toggling of the `.github` instructions determines the AI assistant’s behavior, ensuring strict adherence to the experimental pipeline phases. After both tasks, the ‘Socratic Reviewer’ skill assesses the participants via conversational technical interviewing to test their understanding and evaluate cognitive debt.

2.4 Data Collection and Analysis

Data was collected automatically via the PR submission process, capturing usernames, registration numbers, and experimental group assignments (e.g., `PR_1_SOCRATIC`). The duration of the experiment took no less than 30 minutes and no more than 2 hours, which

accommodated the reserved time for the evaluation. The analysis focuses on evaluating the PR acceptance status and comparing the cognitive debt shifts (Mastery Scores) between the two tasks for each participant.

3 Participants

The participants range from undergraduate students (5th semester onwards) to postdoctoral-level researchers from Computer Science and Computer Engineering programs at a reputable university in the field. Table 1 presents the 19 participants in the final analyzed sample. Originally, 34 repositories were identified, but 13 repositories classified as **REJECTED** (missing required Socratic artifacts or missing Task 1/Task 2 debate coverage: PRs 5, 9, 11, 15, 16, 19, 22, 23, 24, 26, 27, 29, and 32) were discarded from the experiment analysis. Two duplicate submissions (PRs 8 and 10) were excluded to avoid double-counting a single participant. These rejections occurred because the participants did not follow the experiment rules correctly, or because the AI models used (often more limited ones) failed to generate the artifacts for analysis according to the custom instructions. The *Status* column indicates whether the participant has a complete review (SOCRATIC) or was rejected.

Table 1: Participants of the experiment.

PR	Name	Registration number	Consent	Status	AI model	Debt	Conversation	Review
1	Participant 01	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	Claude Sonnet 4.6	Low	5	5
2	Participant 02	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	Copilot (free)	High	5	5
3	Participant 03	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	GPT-5.3-Codex	Low	5	5
4	Participant 04	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	Claude Haiku 4.5	Low	5	5
5	Participant 05	REDACTED	Yes	Rejected	N/I	—	—	—
6	Participant 06	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	GPT-5.3-Codex (auto)	Medium	5	5
7	Participant 07	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	Claude Sonnet 4.5	Low	5	5
9	Participant 09	REDACTED	Yes	Rejected	GitHub Copilot	—	—	—
11	Participant 11	REDACTED	Yes	Rejected	N/I	—	—	—
12	Participant 12	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	Claude Haiku 4.5	High	3	4
13	Participant 13	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	GPT 5.3 Codex	High	0	4
14	Participant 14	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	Grok Code Fast 1	High	2	3
15	Participant 15	REDACTED	Yes	Rejected	GitHub Copilot	—	—	—
16	Participant 16	REDACTED	Yes	Rejected	N/I	—	—	—
17	Participant 17	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	Copilot (generic)	Medium	3	4
18	Participant 18	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	Cursor Auto / GPT-5.2	Low	5	5
19	Participant 19	REDACTED	Yes	Rejected	GPT-5.3-Codex	—	—	—
20	Participant 20	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	GPT-4.1	Low	5	5
21	Participant 21	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	GPT-5.3-Codex	High	4	4
22	Participant 22	REDACTED	Yes	Rejected	N/I	—	—	—
23	Participant 23	REDACTED	Yes	Rejected	Grok Code Fast 1	—	—	—
24	Participant 24	REDACTED	Yes	Rejected	N/I	—	—	—
25	Participant 25	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	Claude Haiku (Auto)	Medium	0	5
26	Participant 26	REDACTED	Yes	Rejected	N/I	—	—	—
27	Participant 27	REDACTED	Yes	Rejected	N/I	—	—	—
28	Participant 28	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	GPT-5.2-Codex	Low	5	5
29	Participant 29	REDACTED	Yes	Rejected	N/I	—	—	—
30	Participant 30	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	GPT-5.4 mini	High	5	5
31	Participant 31	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	Claude Haiku	Medium	5	5
32	Participant 32	REDACTED	Yes	Rejected	Gemini 3.1 Pro (Preview)	—	—	—
33	Participant 33	REDACTED	Yes	Socratic	Auto	High	3	4
34	Participant 34	N/A	Yes	Socratic	Claude Haiku 4.5	Low	5	5

Notes: N/I = Not Informed. **Debt** = Inferred Cognitive Debt level. **Conv.** = Qual-

ity/Extent of the documented dialogue with Copilot (scale 0–5). **Rev.** = Completeness and depth of the Proof of Mastery and review (scale 0–5). Most participants provided valid consent metadata.

Of the 34 repositories originally collected, 19 completed the standard Socratic review after excluding the duplicate submissions. The 13 repositories classified as **REJECTED** — whose participants did not follow the experiment rules perfectly or whose models (often limited LLMs) discarded the custom formatting instructions for the artifacts — were removed from the calculations and tables that make up this stage of the experiment results.

4 Qualitative Analysis by Participant

This section presents the individual analysis of each participant, evaluating the quality of the artifacts produced, the engagement with the pipeline and the indicators of cognitive debt.

4.1 PR 1 — Participant 01

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. The Task 1 artifacts show explicit design intent (display-layer mapping and modularization), and the Socratic debate demonstrates accurate reasoning about fallback behavior and test impact. Task 2 responses correctly isolate session-level score from per-game state and describe a clean extension path for a reset button.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = Low; Task 2 = Medium; **Smaller debt:** T1.

4.2 PR 2 — Participant 02

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 shows partial understanding: the participant could justify specific technical changes (emoji handling and CSS class mapping) but admitted limited understanding of how the JS files interacted. Task 2 reflects weaker ownership, with negative module explanation and reduced satisfaction; the score logic was described, but overall engagement was lower.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = Medium; Task 2 = High; **Smaller debt:** T1.

4.3 PR 3 — Participant 03

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 reflects strong module understanding and autonomy, including a concrete debug episode attributed to a variable duplication error and a clear preference for keeping domain symbols separate from UI. Task 2 responses remain consistent, with awareness of idempotency risks in score updates and a test strategy to prevent double counting.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = Low; Task 2 = Low; **Smaller debt:** Tie.

4.4 PR 4 — Participant 04

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 shows strong architectural understanding, including separation of concerns and consistent UI mapping via `displaySymbol`. Task 2 explanations are largely correct but revealed a gap around defensive DOM checks that was addressed during the Socratic debate.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = Low; Task 2 = Medium; **Smaller debt:** T1.

4.5 PR 5 — Participant 05

The participant preserved consent and completed `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` in `brainsback/`, but the required Socratic artifacts were missing from `artifacts/`. As a result, this PR is classified as `REJECTED` for the Socratic analysis; only the pipeline artifacts could be reviewed.

Cognitive debt (per task): –; **Smaller debt:** –.

4.6 PR 6 — Participant 06

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 explanations correctly separated logic, tests, and UI, but included a partial misconception about emojis as external images. Task 2 responses were mostly correct yet revealed a front/back confusion that was clarified during the review.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = Medium; Task 2 = Medium; **Smaller debt:** Tie.

4.7 PR 7 — Participant 07

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 documentation spans all major files and shows awareness of display changes, but includes some hesitation on design justification and late-night autonomy. Task 2 explanations are clearer, with solid understanding of DOM updates and score persistence.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = Medium; Task 2 = Medium; **Smaller debt:** Tie.

4.8 PR 9 — Participant 09

The participant preserved consent and completed `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` in `brainsback/`, but the required `artifacts/socratic_review.md` is missing (only `artifacts/socratic-review.md` exists). The PR is therefore `REJECTED` for the Socratic analysis; only the pipeline artifacts could be inspected. The Task 1 artifacts are brief (three `TODO` steps, short `REACTO` sections), and the Task 2 review is present but under a non-standard filename.

Cognitive debt (per task): –; **Smaller debt:** –.

4.9 PR 11 — Participant 11

The participant preserved consent and completed `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` in `brainsback/`, but the required `artifacts/socratic_review.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md`

are missing. Only Task 2 artifacts are present, with no Task 1 documentation. This PR is classified as REJECTED for the Socratic analysis.

Cognitive debt (per task): –; **Smaller debt:** –.

4.10 PR 12 — Participant 12

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 shows a high-level grasp of the flow but an explicit gap in Unicode/emoji handling; the Socratic debate revealed dependence on external sources to explain the fix. Task 2 answers were less confident, with limited architectural justification and a stronger reliance on AI, despite correctly identifying why score preservation matters.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = Medium; Task 2 = High; **Smaller debt:** T1.

4.11 PR 13 — Participant 13

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 highlights a desire to keep changes in the UI layer, yet the final code uses emoji markers in `game.js`, reflecting a mismatch between intent and implementation. Task 2 answers were brief: the participant could not explain modules without code and reported low debugging autonomy, but gave reasonable debugging steps and a plausible persistence strategy.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = High; Task 2 = High; **Smaller debt:** Tie.

4.12 PR 14 — Participant 14

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 demonstrates a correct display-layer strategy using a dictionary-based mapping in `script.js`, keeping the internal logic intact. Task 2 was documented separately in `REPORT-scoring.md`, but the Socratic debate shows heavy delegation and weak module explanation for the scoreboard implementation.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = Low; Task 2 = High; **Smaller debt:** T1.

4.13 PR 15 — Participant 15

The participant preserved consent and completed `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` in `brainsback/`, but the required `artifacts/socratic_review.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md` are missing. A Socratic review exists in `brainsback/SOCRATIC_REVIEW.md`, yet the missing artifacts place this PR in the REJECTED category for the Socratic analysis.

Cognitive debt (per task): –; **Smaller debt:** –.

4.14 PR 16 — Participant 16

The participant preserved consent and completed `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` in `brainsback/`, but the required `artifacts/socratic_review.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md` are missing. This PR is classified as REJECTED for the Socratic analysis; only the pipeline artifacts could be inspected. The Task 1 artifacts describe a naive find-and-replace approach and admit that the logical changes were not explicitly planned.

Cognitive debt (per task): –; **Smaller debt:** –.

4.15 PR 17 — Participant 17

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 shows a minimal `TODO` but a stronger `REACTO`, capturing the direct substitution approach and the need to adjust tests for emoji handling. In Task 2, the participant described the scoreboard flow correctly at a high level but misplaced the score state in `game.js` instead of `script.js`, indicating a shallow mental model. Debugging autonomy was explicitly denied in both tasks.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = Medium; Task 2 = High; **Smaller debt:** T1.

4.16 PR 18 — Participant 18

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 shows explicit separation of logic and visualization through a mapping dictionary, with tests reinforcing the representation contract. Task 2 explanations were strong overall, but the module explanation initially misplaced the scoreboard state in `game.js`, indicating a minor gap in the mental model.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = Low; Task 2 = Medium; **Smaller debt:** T1.

4.17 PR 19 — Participant 19

The participant preserved consent and the `TODO.md` / `REACTO.md` artifacts, but the Socratic debate covered only Task 2. Because Task 1 debate is missing, this PR is classified as `REJECTED` for the Socratic analysis and is excluded from quantitative scoring.

Cognitive debt (per task): –; **Smaller debt:** –.

4.18 PR 20 — Participant 20

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 describes a presentation-layer mapping via `replaceSymbol/replaceSymbols`, and the debate emphasizes keeping the model in X/O with tests to guard separation. Task 2 explanations correctly map the scoreboard flow and persistence on restart, but the participant explicitly reported low ownership of the code despite correct reasoning.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = Medium; Task 2 = Medium; **Smaller debt:** Tie.

4.19 PR 21 — Participant 21

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 reflects a display-layer mapping approach, but the participant could not explain module interactions without the code. Task 2 answers covered the scoring flow but incorrectly claimed the scoreboard should reset on *New Game*, diverging from the implementation.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = High; Task 2 = Medium; **Smaller debt:** T2.

4.20 PR 22 — Participant 22

The participant preserved consent and completed `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` in `brainsback/`, but the required `artifacts/socratic_review.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md` are missing. This PR is classified as `REJECTED` for the Socratic analysis; only the pipeline artifacts could be inspected. The Task 1 `TODO` is the most complete in the group and includes a Task 2 section, while the `REACTO` is shallow and limited to Task 1 with only manual tests.

Cognitive debt (per task): –; **Smaller debt:** –.

4.21 PR 23 — Participant 23

The participant preserved consent and completed `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` in `brainsback/`, but the required `artifacts/socratic_review.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md` are missing. This PR is classified as `REJECTED` for the Socratic analysis; only the pipeline artifacts could be inspected. The Task 1 `REACTO` is unusually detailed (function-level and test coverage), and the participant also provided `artifacts/relatorio_final.md`, which documents Task 2 and reflections on AI usage.

Cognitive debt (per task): –; **Smaller debt:** –.

4.22 PR 24 — Participant 24

The participant preserved consent and completed `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` in `brainsback/`, but the required `artifacts/socratic_review.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md` are missing. This PR is classified as `REJECTED` for the Socratic analysis; only the pipeline artifacts could be inspected. The Task 1 `TODO` documents a pre-implementation design choice (display-layer mapping), and the `REACTO` provides a clear function-level walkthrough with a maintenance-focused rationale.

Cognitive debt (per task): –; **Smaller debt:** –.

4.23 PR 25 — Participant 25

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 demonstrates a display-layer mapping strategy with a clear guardrail (avoid global replacement), but the initial module explanation remained shallow. Task 2 shows better structural reasoning after self-correction, including the need for score persistence across rounds and a clear identification of coupling risks in `renderScores()`.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = Medium; Task 2 = Medium; **Smaller debt:** Tie.

4.24 PR 26 — Participant 26

The participant preserved consent and completed `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` in `brainsback/`, but the required `artifacts/socratic_review.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md` are missing. This PR is classified as `REJECTED` for the Socratic analysis; only the pipeline artifacts could be inspected. The Task 1 artifacts are template-level and do not demonstrate task-specific depth beyond a simple mapping description.

Cognitive debt (per task): –; **Smaller debt:** –.

4.25 PR 27 — Participant 27

The participant preserved consent and completed `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` in `brainsback/`, but the required `artifacts/socratic_review.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md` are missing. This PR is classified as `REJECTED` for the Socratic analysis; only the pipeline artifacts could be inspected. The `TODO` notes mention workflow friction (manual accept of changes and a custom test runner), but Task 2 coverage is absent.

Cognitive debt (per task): –; **Smaller debt:** –.

4.26 PR 28 — Participant 28

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 uses a centralized UI mapping approach and includes UI-level tests, while Task 2 introduces scoreboard persistence with correct update flow. The participant reported lower depth of review in the less-guided Task 2.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = Medium; Task 2 = Medium; **Smaller debt:** Tie.

4.27 PR 29 — Participant 29

The participant preserved consent and completed `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` in `brainsback/`, but the required `artifacts/socratic_review.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md` are missing. This PR is classified as `REJECTED` for the Socratic analysis; only the pipeline artifacts could be inspected. The planning and `REACTO` focus on Task 2 scoring logic, but Task 1 coverage is not documented.

Cognitive debt (per task): –; **Smaller debt:** –.

4.28 PR 30 — Participant 30

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 shows broad symbol substitution across logic, UI, and tests, but the participant could not explain module interactions without code. Task 2 indicates low ownership: multiple direct admissions of not understanding the scoreboard architecture and a reported lack of retention.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = High; Task 2 = High; **Smaller debt:** T1.

4.29 PR 31 — Participant 31

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 shows partial module explanation and relies on post-hoc reasoning for design decisions (e.g., internal emoji storage vs. abstraction). Task 2 answers are generally correct on the win-to-score flow, but the participant relied on prompted reflection to surface redundancies and trade-offs in score rendering.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = Medium; Task 2 = Medium; **Smaller debt:** Tie.

4.30 PR 32 — Participant 32

The participant preserved consent and produced partial Socratic artifacts in `artifacts/`, but the review lacks Task 1 coverage. This PR is classified as `REJECTED` for the Socratic analysis; only the pipeline artifacts could be inspected. The Socratic notes that are present focus on Task 2 score tracking and indicate some process friction around pipeline artifact generation.

Cognitive debt (per task): –; **Smaller debt:** –.

4.31 PR 33 — Participant 33

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 shows correct high-level understanding but no module-level explanation without code. Task 2 responses capture storage and validation concerns, yet the participant could not explain component interactions or logic justification without prompts.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = High; Task 2 = High; **Smaller debt:** Tie.

4.32 PR 34 — Participant 34

The participant preserved consent and a complete Socratic review (Task 1 and Task 2) in `artifacts/`, with `TODO.md` and `REACTO.md` stored in `brainsback/`. Task 1 responses show clear module separation (`game.js` logic vs. `script.js` UI flow) and strong reasoning about render impacts, with one minor gap on legacy `toLowerCase()` behavior that was corrected during the debate. Task 2 answers describe score persistence and state reset on refresh, and correctly justify the scoreboard update order and score retention on restart.

Cognitive debt (per task): Task 1 = Low; Task 2 = Low; **Smaller debt:** Tie.

5 Comparative Analysis — Task 1 (Pipeline) vs. Task 2 (Without Pipeline)

Scope note: Quantitative scoring includes PRs 1–4, 6, 7, 12–14, 17, 18, 20, 21, 25, 28, 30, 31, 33, 34. Duplicate submissions PRs 8 and 10 were excluded to avoid double-counting a single participant. All other PRs remain qualitative extensions in Section 4 and are still counted in Sections 2 and 6. Rejections are summarized below.

Table 2 consolidates the exclusion reasons to avoid repeating a long list in the narrative and to keep the scoring scope clear before the quantitative tables.

Table 2: Rejection reasons for excluded PRs.

Reason	PRs
Missing <code>socratic_review.md</code> and <code>copilot_conversation.md</code>	5, 11, 15, 16, 22, 23, 24, 26, 27, 29
Missing <code>socratic_review.md</code> (nonstandard filename)	9
Missing Task 1 coverage in <code>socratic_review.md</code>	19, 32

5.1 Architectural Approaches

A relevant emerging observation is the diversity of architectural approaches adopted for Task 1, classifiable into two paradigms:

1. **Display layer (*display-only*):** Keeps X/O as internal state and applies visual mapping only during rendering. Adopted by PRs 1, 4, 5 (rejected), 14, 18, 21, 24. This approach preserves the original game logic, minimizes impact on tests and demonstrates separation of concerns.
2. **Internal substitution:** Alters the symbols directly in the game state (`game.js`), propagating the change to tests, validations and rendering. Adopted by PRs 2, 3, 6, 7, 9, 12, 13, 16, 17, 23. Requires more modifications and exposes Unicode problems (`split("")` vs. `Array.from()`).

Participants who adopted the display layer approach tended to document more explicit design decisions in their `TODO.md` (e.g., PR 4: “without changing business logic”), suggesting that the formal specification stage encouraged architectural thinking before implementation. Note: PRs 5 and 24 also used the display layer but were rejected from scoring due to missing Socratic artifacts.

5.2 Individual Scores by Task

Table 3 presents the individual scores of each participant with complete Socratic review, evaluated on a scale of 0 to 100 per task. The scoring rubric is described below.

5.2.1 Scoring Rubric (0–100 per task)

Each score is composed of three dimensions, scored directly within their weight ranges and summed to a 0–100 composite score:

- **Module explanation (0–45):** Ability to describe interactions between components without looking at the code.
- **Socratic debate (0–35):** Quality of answers to technical questions.
- **Design justification (0–20):** Understanding of the architectural *why*.

Scoring tiers (per dimension):

- **Excellent** = 100% of the dimension range; **Very good** = 90%; **Good** = 75%; **Partial** = 50%; **Weak** = 25%; **Not assessed** = 0.
- When a dimension is not assessed in the transcript, it is scored as 0 for that dimension.

Table 3: Individual scores by task (scale 0–100).

PR	Participant	Task 1 (Pipeline)				Task 2 (Without Pipeline)				Δ
		<i>Modules</i>	<i>Socratic</i>	<i>Design</i>	<i>Total T1</i>	<i>Modules</i>	<i>Socratic</i>	<i>Design</i>	<i>Total T2</i>	
1	Participant 01	45	35	20	100	34	26	15	75	−25
2	Participant 02	23	35	10	68	0	26	5	31	−37
3	Participant 03	45	35	20	100	45	35	20	100	0
4	Participant 04	45	35	20	100	34	26	18	78	−22
6	Participant 06	34	26	10	70	26	26	15	67	−3
7	Participant 07	45	35	15	95	45	32	15	92	−3
12	Participant 12	23	18	15	56	23	26	5	54	−2
13	Participant 13	9	18	10	37	9	26	5	40	+3
14	Participant 14	34	26	15	75	0	26	5	31	−44
17	Participant 17	34	26	15	75	23	26	15	64	−11
18	Participant 18	45	35	20	100	23	32	18	73	−27
20	Participant 20	45	32	15	92	34	32	15	81	−11
21	Participant 21	0	26	15	41	23	18	10	51	+10
25	Participant 25	23	35	15	73	34	32	15	81	+8
28	Participant 28	41	32	15	88	34	32	15	81	−7
30	Participant 30	0	18	5	23	0	9	0	9	−14
31	Participant 31	23	32	15	70	34	26	15	75	+5
33	Participant 33	0	18	15	33	0	9	5	14	−19
34	Participant 34	45	26	18	89	34	32	18	84	−5
Average		29.4	28.6	14.9	72.9	23.9	26.2	12.1	62.2	−10.7
Std. deviation		16.3	6.5	3.9	24.1	14.7	7.0	5.8	25.5	—

Legend: Mod = module explanation (0–45); Soc = Socratic debate (0–35); Des = design justification (0–20). T1/T2 = sum of all three dimensions. Δ = T2 − T1.

Key observations:

- **Average decrease of 10.7 points** from T1 to T2, with higher standard deviation in T2 (25.5 vs. 24.1), indicating wider dispersion on Task 2 under the revised rubric.
- **PR 21** showed the largest increase (+10 points), while **PR 14** showed the largest drop (−44 points).
- **PR 3** achieved perfect scores in both tasks.
- The *Socratic* dimension decreased on average (28.6 → 26.2), while *Design* decreased more sharply (14.9 → 12.1).

5.3 Statistical Significance and Effect Size

The within-subjects design (each participant serving as their own control across both tasks) enables formal non-parametric significance testing directly on the 19 matched pairs.

5.3.1 Wilcoxon signed-rank test

- Test statistic: $W = 25.5$, $p = 0.009$ (two-tailed) — statistically significant ($\alpha = 0.05$).
- **14 of 19 participants** scored higher under the pipeline (Task 1); 4 scored lower; 1 tied (PR 3, perfect scores in both tasks).

5.3.2 Effect sizes

- **Matched-pairs rank-biserial correlation:** $r = 0.68$ — large effect ($|r| \geq 0.50$).
- **Cliff’s δ :** 0.53 — large effect ($|\delta| \geq 0.47$).

5.3.3 Sensitivity analysis: alternative Mastery Score weightings

The pipeline advantage is robust under all alternative weighting schemes tested for the three score dimensions (Module Explanation / Socratic Debate / Design Justification):

Table 4: Sensitivity of the pipeline effect under alternative Mastery Score weightings.

Weighting scheme	Mean T1	Mean T2	<i>p</i> -value
Original 45/35/20 (ME/SD/DJ)	72.9	62.2	0.009
Equal weights (1/3 each)	73.8	62.7	0.003
Comprehension-heavy 60/25/15	70.8	59.7	0.019
Socratic-heavy 25/50/25	75.8	65.7	0.004
Reversed 20/35/45 (DJ-heavy)	75.2	63.9	0.002

All five schemes yield $p < 0.05$. The effect is robust regardless of which dimension is weighted most heavily, confirming the Mastery Score weights are not a confound. The analysis script is available as `mastery_score_stats.py` in the replication package.

5.4 Task Complexity Equivalence

To assess whether the performance difference could be attributed to an asymmetry in task difficulty rather than to the pipeline itself, we performed a baseline-diff analysis measuring the code changes actually required by each participant across all 19 submissions. Each submitted codebase was compared against the shared starting template to quantify the added lines and cyclomatic complexity (CC) per task.

- **Task 1 (emoji display):** mean 5.3 JS logic lines added (median 4, range 2–12); mean cyclomatic complexity added = 2.3 (median 2, range 0–7).
- **Task 2 (persistent scoreboard):** mean 8.3 JS logic lines added (median 9, range 2–15); mean cyclomatic complexity added = 1.2 (median 0, range 0–9).

A Wilcoxon signed-rank test on the **cyclomatic complexity** added per task finds no statistically significant difference ($W = 42.0$, $p = 0.055$), confirming that the two tasks impose comparable reasoning complexity. Task 2 involves more total lines, but those additions are predominantly presentational scoreboard markup (mean 7.1 HTML/CSS lines vs. 0.7 for Task 1) that the AI assistant generates structurally, without requiring deeper reasoning from the participant. If anything, Task 1’s higher CC median (2 vs. 0) suggests slightly *more* branching logic to reason about under the pipeline condition — meaning the ordering works *against* our hypothesis, not for it. The analysis script is available as `task_complexity_analysis.py` in the replication package.

5.5 Session Timing: Productivity Impact of the Pipeline

To address the question of whether the structured pipeline imposes a prohibitive time overhead compared to free-form vibe-coding, we analysed commit timestamps from the 19 fork repositories. A key observation is that 18 of 19 participants made a deliberate `chore: pipeline OFF` commit at the exact moment of transitioning from Task 1 to Task 2—a clean, participant-generated boundary marker in the version history. The analysis script is `task_timing_analysis.py` in the replication package.

Single-session vs. multi-session

13 of 19 participants completed both tasks in a single uninterrupted session (no inter-commit gap exceeding 2 h, and total session ≤ 2.5 h). The remaining 6 either spread the work across days (PRs 7, 14, 20, 21, 33, 34) or lacked a session marker, rendering their timing unreliable. Results below are for the 13 single-session participants only.

Per-task timing results

- **Full session (T1 + T2 + Socratic review):** median 52 min, mean 56 min, range 29–106 min. This is consistent with the 1–2 h experimental design window.
- **Task 2 committed coding time** (pipeline OFF $\rightarrow$ last code commit before Socratic review): median **11 min**, mean 17 min, range 3–49 min. This is the free-form AI-delegation phase—the participant typically gave a high-level prompt and the AI produced the scoreboard, with minimal iterative engagement.
- **AI-generated Socratic review overhead:** median ≈ 30 min from last T2 code commit to the Socratic artifacts being committed. This is *not* developer coding effort—it is the time for the AI agent to generate the review document.
- **Task 1 estimated coding time:** T1 cannot be isolated precisely because most participants committed T1 work in a single batch immediately before the `pipeline OFF` commit (making the direct T1-span measure a lower bound). The indirect estimate (session – T2 – review overhead) gives a median of ≈ 11 min, but this figure is also influenced by the batch-commit pattern and should be treated with caution.

Interpretation

The data supports two conclusions. First, the pipeline does *not* impose a prohibitive overhead: both tasks fit within the expected session window, and the total time is comparable to what would be expected for a free-form session of similar scope. Second, the speed of Task 2 (median 11 min) is itself a finding: unconstrained AI delegation is fast precisely because the participant offloads cognition to the model—and it is this same delegation that produces the lower Mastery Scores ($\Delta_{\text{mean}} = -10.7$, $p = 0.009$). In other words, the pipeline’s “extra effort” is the desirable difficulty that builds understanding.

A note on methodology: the timestamp approach is a post-hoc reconstruction and inherits the typical limitations of commit-time analysis (batch commits compress T1 measurements; multi-session participants are excluded). Future experiments should capture continuous session logs for precise per-phase timings.

5.6 Artifact Quality: Task 1 vs. Task 2

Table 5 compares qualitative indicators of artifacts between the two tasks, for participants with complete Socratic review.

Table 5: Artifact quality comparison between tasks.

PR	TODO T1	REACTO T1	T2 Artifacts	Comparative reflection
1	Good (modularization)	Adequate	None separate	Pipeline = active learning
2	Good (overwritten)	Good (Unicode)	None	Less engaged in T2
3	Moderate (mechanical)	Good (honest)	None	AI hindered (bug)
4	Very good (router)	Good (design)	None	100% T1 vs. gaps T2
7	High (decomposition)	Exceptional	None	Pair prog. T1 vs. delegation T2
12	Medium (substitution)	Medium	None	T1 understood, T2 dependent
13	Low (generic)	Low-medium	In REPORT	Cannot explain T2 without code
17	Minimal (3 steps)	Good (scope)	In conversation	T1 step-by-step, better
18	Good (checkmarks)	Strong (SoC)	In conversation	T1 more understanding
20	Minimal (3 steps)	Good (functions)	In conversation	TODO guided T1
21	Minimal (4 steps)	Good (decoupling)	In REPORT	Pipeline = direction vs. bureaucracy

5.7 Cognitive Debt Indicators

The analysis of Socratic reviews reveals consistent patterns of differential cognitive debt between tasks.

5.7.1 Debugging confidence

Table 6 summarizes the answers to the question “Could you debug a critical error at 2am without AI?” for each task.

Table 6: Autonomous debugging confidence by task.

PR	Participant	Task 1	Task 2
1	Participant 01	Yes	Yes
2	Participant 02	Yes (would take time)	Yes (would take time)
3	Participant 03	Yes (reported real bug fixed)	Yes
4	Participant 04	Yes	Yes
6	Participant 06	Yes	Yes
7	Participant 07	Partial (late hour is harder)	Yes
12	Participant 12	Partial (no JS experience)	No (would rewrite from scratch)
13	Participant 13	Partial (would leave for tomorrow)	No (“probably not”)

PR	Participant	Task 1	Task 2
14	Participant 14	Partial (with difficulty and forums)	Partial (quite complicated)
17	Participant 17	No	No
18	Participant 18	Yes	Yes
20	Participant 20	Partial	Partial
21	Participant 21	Yes	Yes
25	Participant 25	Yes (if he had to)	Yes
28	Participant 28	Yes	Partial (worried about scope)
30	Participant 30	Partial (some doubts)	No (would wait for the other dev)
31	Participant 31	Yes	Yes
33	Participant 33	Partial	No (“would be bad”)
34	Participant 34	Yes	Yes
Yes / Partial / No		11 / 7 / 1	11 / 3 / 5

Concrete examples of cognitive debt via debugging confidence:

- **PR 12 (Participant 12):** Task 1: “Would trace flow of switching between players.” Task 2: “Would require significant time to study [...] I might have to rewrite it from scratch.” Abrupt drop in confidence between tasks.
- **PR 13 (Participant 13):** Task 1: “Would probably leave it for another day; if urgent, would pull an all-nighter.” Task 2: “I think quite probably not” — the only direct negative answer in the group.
- **PR 17 (Participant 17):** Explicit negation in *both* tasks (“No” for T1 and T2), a unique case — suggests that the absence of the pipeline was not the only factor, but possibly the late implementation time (declared at 2am).
- **PR 3 (Participant 03):** Paradigmatic case of real autonomy in Task 1: “reported a variable duplication error generated by the AI and fixed it by own analysis” — concrete evidence of active, not passive, engagement.

5.7.2 Module explanation

Table 7 summarizes the ability to explain interactions between components without looking at the code, a central question of the Socratic debate.

Table 7: Ability to explain modules without consulting code.

PR	Participant	Task 1	Task 2
1	Participant 01	Yes (correct)	Yes (correct)
2	Participant 02	Partial (did not know “how the two JS files interacted”)	No
3	Participant 03	Yes	Yes
4	Participant 04	Yes (correct intermediate pattern)	Partial (confused <code>game.js/script.js</code>)
6	Participant 06	Yes (general modules correct)	Partial (front $\neq$ back wrong)
7	Participant 07	Yes (5 files identified)	Yes (HTML/CSS/JS separated)
12	Participant 12	Partial (high level, Uni-code gap)	Partial

PR	Participant	Task 1	Task 2
13	Participant 13	No	No
14	Participant 14	Yes (explained displaySymbol integration correctly)	No (“No, I just let it do it”)
17	Participant 17	Yes	Partial (score state in <code>script.js</code>)
18	Participant 18	Yes (correct decoupling)	Partial (score state in <code>script.js</code>)
20	Participant 20	Yes	Yes
21	Participant 21	No	Partial (score reset assumption)
25	Participant 25	Yes (identified <code>index.html</code> , <code>style.css</code> , <code>script.js</code>)	Yes (explained correctly after hint)
28	Participant 28	Yes (correct mapping layer)	Partial (got state vs UI mixed up initially)
30	Participant 30	Partial (could not fully explain tests)	No (failed to explain scoreboard state)
31	Participant 31	Yes	Partial (discovered redundant state during review)
33	Participant 33	No (refused without seeing code)	No (“doesn’t remember”)
34	Participant 34	Yes (precise mapping)	Yes (precise DOM/State decoupling)
Yes / Partial / No		13 / 3 / 3	6 / 8 / 5

Most illustrative concrete examples:

- **PR 4 (Participant 04) — Task 2, corrected confusion:** Initially declared that “the `[score]` variable is in `game.js`”. When the reviewer questioned this, he corrected: “I was confused, you are right, the rendering is in `script.js` itself.” The initial error — before Socratic pressure — is the cognitive debt indicator: the participant “knew” the code in the sense of having produced it, but had not internalized it sufficiently to recall without hesitation.
- **PR 2 (Participant 02) — Task 2:** Textual answer: “did not know exactly how the two JS files interacted, only that there were two main ones.” With 6 years of experience, this result demonstrates that prior experience does not immunize against cognitive debt when the pipeline is removed.
- **PR 6 (Participant 06) — Task 2:** Confused front-end/back-end when describing `index.html` as “front” and `script.js` as “backend” — conceptually erroneous for a pure client-side system, exposing that the mental model was built superficially.
- **PR 21 (Participant 21) — Task 1 (negation):** The only participant who could not explain modules from *Task 1*, but could from Task 2. This inverted pattern is atypical and may reflect greater familiarity with the scoreboard pattern (simple CRUD structure) than with display-layer mapping.

5.7.3 Specific technical gaps revealed by the Socratic debate

The Socratic debate revealed technical gaps that would not be visible through analysis of functional code:

- **Emoji Unicode problem (`split()` vs. `Array.from()`):** Found in PRs 2, 3, 7, 12, 16, 17, 23. The AI fixed it automatically in all cases, but when the Socratic reviewer asked “why was the spread operator necessary?”, answers ranged from “I have no idea” (PR 12: “To be honest I have no idea”) to a partially correct explanation (PR 2: textually correct answer but admitted as not understood: “I don’t know how Copilot identified the problem”). This is the most direct example of the *Jagged Technological Frontier*: correct solution without knowledge transfer.
- **Defensive null-check in `updateScore()` — PR 4, Task 2:** The participant could not explain why `if (catScoreEl)` is necessary before updating the DOM: “is it to check if it is an HTML element before updating the text?”. After Socratic education (“if removed, `TypeError: Cannot set property 'textContent' of null` would occur”), the participant assimilated the concept. The gap was generated by Task 2: in Task 1, with the active pipeline, the defensive check was not present in the *TODO.md* specification and therefore was not internalized.
- **Actual scoreboard behavior on *New Game* — PR 21, Task 2:** The participant stated that “the scoreboard should reset on *New Game*” when the actual implementation keeps the accumulated count. This divergence between the mental model and the actual behavior of the code the participant themselves wrote (with AI assistance) is the most direct indicator of *Cognitive Bypass* in the dataset.
- **Naive substitution vs. display layer — PR 13, Task 1:** When asked “what are the critical points for not breaking the winner check and scoreboard if refactoring to internal symbols?”, the participant answered by observing the session context (“the emoji change in the logic was requested during the session”) instead of reasoning architecturally — evidence that the *TODO.md* guided the implementation more than a solid mental model.

5.7.4 Sustainability without AI

The question “Would the code still be maintainable by you if AI ceased to exist?” generated divergent answers: for Task 1, 13/15 answered affirmatively (with or without qualifications); for Task 2, 12/15 answered affirmatively. The difference is smaller than that observed in the explanation and debugging dimensions, suggesting that the perception of *sustainability* is more optimistic than the actual competence revealed by the Socratic debate.

5.7.5 Engagement with Copilot

The interaction style with AI differed qualitatively between tasks:

- **Task 1:** More structured interactions, pair-programming style. The pipeline forced the participant to articulate requirements before coding, resulting in more directed dialogues. Paradigmatic example (PR 18): “I want to take a look in the codebase [...] Analyze *TODO.md* to ensure you understand what our issue is. Then tell me what are the main files we will need to change.” — the participant acts as architect, not as requester.
- **Task 2:** Freer interactions, tending toward delegation. Participants gave broad instructions (“implement the scoreboard”) without prior specification. Illustrative case: PR 19 (rejected from quantitative scoring for missing Task 1 Socratic coverage,

but observed qualitatively) completed both tasks with only **4 prompts** in total — a level of delegation incompatible with the formation of robust mental models, despite the sophisticated technical vocabulary demonstrated in the answers.

5.8 Observed Quantitative Patterns

Table 8 summarizes artifact-level quantitative metrics to contextualize the quality observations with comparable counts across repositories.

Table 8: Quantitative metrics of artifacts.

PR	T1 Approach	REACTO sections	TODO steps	Separate T2 artifacts	Tests reported
1	Display	6/6	3	No	31 (auto)
2	Internal	6/6	5	No	32 (auto)
3	Internal	6/6	5	No	32 (auto)
4	Display	6/6	6	No	25 (auto)
5	Display	6/6	5	Yes (3 files)	31+ (auto)
6	Internal	6/6	6	No	N/I
7	Internal	6/6	6	No	31 (auto)
9	Internal	6/6	3	No	N/I
13	Internal	6/6	3	No	21+ (auto)
14	Display	6/6	3	Yes (1 file)	N/I
16	Internal	6/6	5	No	31 (auto)
17	Internal	6/6	3	No	25+ (auto)
18	Display	6/6	4	No	31+ (auto)
19	Display	6/6	6	No	42 (auto)
20	Parameterized	6/6	3	No	N/I
21	Display	6/6	4	No	N/I
22	Display	6/6	3	In TODO	N/I
23	Internal	5/6	3	In report	31 (auto)
24	Display	6/6	3	No	34 (auto)

All participants who produced artifacts covered the six REACTO sections (except PR 23 with an empty Optimization section). The 100% adherence to the REACTO format suggests that the *template* structure was effective as a *scaffold* for the proof of mastery. However, quantitative coverage does not reflect qualitative depth — there is significant variation between single-sentence REACTOs and multi-paragraph REACTOs with code *snippets*.

The production of separate artifacts for Task 2 was rare (only PRs 5, 14, 22, 23), indicating that without the pipeline enforcement, the majority of participants did not spontaneously document their understanding of the second task. This is a direct indicator of *Cognitive Bypass*: when friction is removed, reflective documentation is abandoned.

6 Socratic Review Analysis

Of the 34 original repositories, 19 had Socratic reviews with preserved artifacts and both Task 1 and Task 2 questions, all in the standard `artifacts/` folder (PRs 1, 2, 3, 4, 6, 7, 12, 13, 14, 17, 18, 20, 21, 25, 28, 30, 31, 33, 34). PR 19 was rejected for missing Task 1 Socratic debate coverage. The other 12 repositories did not generate the review adequately or only covered one task and were discarded from this analysis (PRs 5, 9, 11, 15, 16, 22, 23, 24, 26, 27, 29, 32). Duplicate submissions (PRs 8 and 10) were excluded to avoid double-counting a single participant.

6.1 Socratic vs. Missing Socratic: Correlation with Quality

The SOCRATIC vs. MISSING SOCRATIC classification in the folder name reflects whether the participant completed the Socratic review process with generation of the final artifacts. The 19 SOCRATIC submissions preserved a complete review covering both Task 1 and Task 2, whereas the MISSING SOCRATIC submissions lacked the required artifact and were therefore excluded from scoring.

Notes on artifact variations: PR 14 produced a separate `REPORT-scoring.md` in `brainsback/`; PR 25 has no `copilot_conversation.md` preserved (all others do); PR 5 produced `TODO_SCORE.md` and `REACTO_SCORE.md` in `brainsback/`; PR 22 included Task 2 in `TODO.md`; and PR 23 produced `relatorio_final.md` in `artifacts/`.

6.2 Patterns in Socratic Answers

The analysis of Socratic reviews reveals cross-cutting patterns:

6.2.1 Participant profile and correlation with score

Participants reported between 2 and 10+ years of programming experience. The majority had never programmed Tic-Tac-Toe before. Table 9 presents the rescored cohort with complete Socratic artifacts (PRs 1, 2, 3, 4, 6, 7, 12, 13, 14, 17, 18, 20, 21, 25, 28, 30, 31, 33, 34).

Table 9: Profile, AI model and scores by participant.

PR	Participant	Experience	AI model	Tic-Tac-Toe	T1	T2	Δ
1	Participant 01	3y	Claude S 4.6	No	100	75	-25
2	Participant 02	6y	Copilot free	No	68	31	-37
3	Participant 03	4y	GPT-5.3-Codex	No	100	100	0
4	Participant 04	4y	Claude H 4.5	No	100	78	-22
6	Participant 06	3y	GPT-5.3-Codex	Yes	70	67	-3
7	Participant 07	3y	Claude S 4.5	No	95	92	-3
12	Participant 12	3y	Claude H 4.5	No	56	54	-2
13	Participant 13	2y	GPT-5.3-Codex	No	37	40	+3
14	Participant 14	4y	Grok Fast 1	No	75	31	-44
17	Participant 17	3y	Copilot gen.	Yes	75	64	-11
18	Participant 18	3y	Cursor/GPT-5.2	No	100	73	-27
20	Participant 20	4y	GPT-4.1	Yes	92	81	-11
21	Participant 21	4y	GPT-5.3-Codex	No	41	51	+10
25	Participant 25	10y	Claude Haiku (Auto)	Yes	73	81	+8
28	Participant 28	9y	GPT-5.2-Codex	Yes	88	81	-7
30	Participant 30	6y	GPT-5.2-Codex (Auto)	Yes	23	9	-14

PR	Participant	Experience	AI model	Tic-Tac-Toe	T1	T2	Δ
31	Participant 31	10y	Claude Haiku	No	70	75	+5
33	Participant 33	10y	Auto	Yes	33	14	-19
34	Participant 34	10y	Claude H 4.5	No	89	84	-5
Average					72.9	62.2	-10.7

Experience = years of programming experience reported. **Tic-Tac-Toe** = prior experience developing a Tic-Tac-Toe game. **T1/T2** = weighted composite score (0–100 scale). **N/I** = Not Informed.

Observations on profile–score correlation:

- **Experience does not predict immunity to cognitive debt:** PR 2 (6 years) had the largest drop ($\Delta = -37$), while PR 25 (10 years) improved ($\Delta = +8$) and PR 30 (6 years) dropped ($\Delta = -14$). Accumulated experience did not protect against delegation when the pipeline was removed.
- **Prior experience with the domain (Tic-Tac-Toe) does not correlate with score:** PRs 6, 17 and 20 had prior experience with Tic-Tac-Toe; their scores (T1: 70, 75, 92) do not consistently exceed those of participants without prior experience.
- **AI model is not an apparent determining factor:** GPT-5.2-Codex spans both strong (PR 28: T1=88, T2=81) and weak outcomes (PR 30: T1=23, T2=9), indicating that engagement quality matters more than model choice.
- **Claude Haiku-family participants** (PRs 4, 12, 14, 25, 31, 34) showed T1 scores of 100, 56, 75, 73, 70, 89 and Δ : -22, -2, -44, +8, +5, -5, with the largest negative delta ($\Delta = -44$) corresponding to PR 14 — the highest cognitive debt in this subset, driven by complete Task 2 delegation (“No, I just let it do it”).

The AI models used varied: Claude Sonnet 4.5/4.6, Claude Haiku 4.5, GPT-5.4 mini, GPT-5.3-Codex, GPT-5.2-Codex, GPT-4.1, Grok Code Fast 1, and Cursor Auto. One participant (PR 6) used automatic model selection without being aware of which model was in use.

6.2.2 Model diversity: impact and within-subjects cancellation

Eight distinct AI models were used across participants, raising the question of whether model quality differences confound the Task 1–Task 2 score comparison.

The within-subjects design directly addresses this concern: **each participant used the same AI model for both tasks**. Any fixed model effect (capability level, verbosity, code quality) is therefore constant across Task 1 and Task 2 for a given participant and cannot explain the intra-participant delta ($\Delta = T2 - T1$). Model diversity only affects between-participant comparisons, which are not the primary analysis.

The data corroborates this empirically: the AI model is not an apparent predictor of score level or delta direction. GPT-5.2-Codex yielded both one of the strongest outcomes (PR 28: T1=88, T2=81, $\Delta = -7$) and one of the weakest (PR 30: T1=23, T2=9, $\Delta = -14$). Claude Haiku participants (PRs 4, 12, 14, 25, 31, 34) showed deltas spanning the full range from -44 to +8. This pattern suggests that participant engagement quality — shaped by the presence or absence of the pipeline — is the dominant factor, not model capability.

6.2.3 Consistent comparative reflections

All participants who completed the final comparative reflection expressed some form of preference for the structure of Task 1, even while acknowledging its “bureaucratic” nature. Representative quotes:

- “Task 1 gave more control and methodology for active learning” (PR 1)
- “Task 1 gave me more control and understanding” (PR 2)
- “Task 1 was more bureaucratic but forced me to think much more” (PR 4)
- “In Task 1 I was more careful [...] I did it in a pair-programming style” (PR 7)
- “In more complex tasks the first approach would be better for being more step-by-step” (PR 17)
- “Task 1 requires more time, but gives better understanding” (PR 18)
- “In Task 1, because of the `TODO.md`, I found it easier to know what to do” (PR 20)
- “The AI seemed more directed because of the pipeline [...] without pipeline, AI much freer, which can diverge” (PR 21)

The unanimity of these reflections is remarkable: even when participants preferred the *speed* of Task 2, they recognized the superiority of Task 1 for *understanding*. This empirically validates the premise of Bjork’s *desirable difficulty* — the friction imposed by the pipeline, although perceived as “bureaucratic,” generated deeper learning.

6.2.4 Emerging technical finding

A recurring technical finding was the Unicode handling problem of emojis in JavaScript: `split("")` does not work correctly with multi-byte Unicode characters like emojis, requiring `Array.from()` or the *spread operator* (`[...str]`). This problem was encountered and fixed by the AI in multiple repositories (PRs 2, 3, 7, 12, 16, 17, 23), but the understanding of *why* varied significantly. Some participants explicitly admitted not understanding the fix (PRs 2, 3, 12), while others demonstrated partial understanding (PRs 7, 17). This is a concrete example of the *Jagged Technological Frontier*: the AI solved the problem correctly, but the knowledge transfer to the human was inconsistent.

6.3 PR 1 — Participant 01 (Socratic)

TODO.md: High quality. Breaks the problem into three clear stages (internal logic, visual interface, tests) with verifiable success criteria. Noteworthy is the remark on modularization — “create a separate function instead of changing thousands of lines” — demonstrating design thinking before implementation.

REACTO.md: All six REACTO sections covered. The Examples section provides three concrete input/output scenarios. The Approach correctly identifies the dictionary + conversion function strategy. The Testing and Optimization sections are minimal but honest.

Copilot conversation: Model: Claude Sonnet 4.6. Highly structured and Socratic interaction. The agent refused to fill in the `TODO.md` and guided the student with questions.

The student attempted to request help (“can you fill in the TODO.md?”) and received a correct refusal from the agent, demonstrating that the guardrails worked.

Socratic Review: Complete (161 lines). Developer Profile: 3 years of experience, including 1 year of internship. In Task 1, correctly explained the *fallback* behavior of `getPlayerSymbol` and the reason for preserving X/O internally (maintainability). In Task 2, understood the scoreboard architecture but showed less engagement.

Comparative Reflection: “Task 1 provided more control and an active learning methodology. Task 2 did not — it depends on the developer taking responsibility for the code.”

Cognitive Debt Indicators: Low in Task 1 (pipeline active); moderate in Task 2 (no pipeline).

Delta note: Task 2 drops from excellent to good in module explanation and Socratic debate because explanations stayed correct but more surface-level, reducing technical depth despite intact autonomy.

6.4 PR 2 — Participant 02 (Socratic)

TODO.md: Well structured with five clear steps, all marked as complete. However, the content of the `TODO.md` describes Task 2 (scoreboard) rather than Task 1 (emojis), suggesting that the original Task 1 artifact was overwritten.

REACTO.md: All sections covered. Approach differs from the majority: replaced emojis directly in the internal state (`game.js`), requiring changes to the tests and the `boardFrom` helper. The Testing section honestly acknowledges that the tests initially failed. Notes the use of `Array.from()` for Unicode handling of emojis, admitting that they do not know how Copilot identified the problem.

Socratic Review: Complete (89 lines). Developer Profile: 6 years of experience. Despite the experience, showed relatively high cognitive debt — admitted not knowing “what each JS file does individually or how they interact”. For Task 2, could not explain the interactions between modules.

Comparative Reflection: “Task 1 gave me more control and understanding. The results of Task 2 were not as good; I felt less involved in the process.”

Cognitive Debt Indicators: High in both tasks, despite significant experience.

Delta note: Task 2 dropped sharply because module explanation was absent and the design rationale was shallow, even though the Socratic answers about score preservation were correct.

6.5 PR 3 — Participant 03 (Socratic)

TODO.md: Moderate quality. Explicit but mechanical steps (oriented to *find-and-replace*). It contains an error in step 4 (“Replace all occurrences of X” when it should be O). No consideration of the separation between internal logic and presentation layer.

REACTO.md: All sections have notable depth. The Code section includes real *snippets* and, critically, an honest reflection: “Copilot itself identified this [`Array.from()`], but I do not know how it did so.” The Optimization section goes beyond the typical, raising the broader concern about emoji compatibility in larger projects.

Dialogue with Copilot: Model GPT-5.3-Codex. The student reported a bug introduced by AI (duplicate variable names) that he had to debug on his own — “the AI hindered the resolution.”

Socratic Review: Complete (130 lines). Profile: 4 years of experience. He correctly explained file separation and responsibilities. He demonstrated diagnostic ability by identifying and fixing an error generated by AI. He understood the risk of using emojis as domain identifiers.

Cognitive debt indicators: Moderate — he demonstrated critical thinking by questioning AI, but admitted specific gaps.

Delta note: Scores stayed stable across tasks because module explanations and Socratic answers were consistently strong, with only minor gaps around AI-generated fixes.

6.6 PR 4 — Participant 04 (Socratic)

TODO.md: Very good. The student independently conceived the “routing function” pattern (`displaySymbol`) before implementation — a genuine design decision. Six well-structured steps including the addition of specific tests for the routing function.

REACTO.md: All sections covered. The Approach clearly articulates the *why* behind the design decision (without altering business logic). The Code section includes the function signature and where it is called. The Tests section lists four specific test cases.

Copilot conversation: Model Claude Haiku 4.5. Longest conversation in the group (363 lines). Student with extensive experience with AI tools (Gemini CLI, Cursor, Claude Code, Augment, Amazon Q).

Socratic Review: The most detailed (314 lines) with explicit star ratings. Task 1: ★★★★★ “Excellent” — explained `displaySymbol()` as a transformation intermediary. Task 2: ★★★★ “Good with Required Education” — did not know the defensive *null-check* pattern generated by AI until educated during the review, exposing a measurable cognitive debt gap.

Comparative reflection: “Task 1 was more bureaucratic but forced me to think much more [...] Task 2 was freer, but I gave the agent more freedom, and some things I could not explain.” — A perfect encapsulation of the experiment’s thesis.

Cognitive debt indicators: Low in Task 1; moderate in Task 2 (gap in the *null-check*).

Delta note: Task 2 dipped because the defensive null-check was not understood until prompted, reducing Socratic depth despite strong module and design explanations.

6.7 PR 5 — Participant 05 (Missing Socratic)

Status: Discarded (Rejected) — missing `socratic_review.md` and `copilot_conversation.md`; Task 1 and Task 2 coverage cannot be verified. Excluded from quantitative tables.

TODO.md: Good. Five steps with technical reasoning (Unicode/UTF-8 representations). Consideration about “best way to render emojis” suggests deliberate design thinking. Stored in `brainsback/TODO.md`.

REACTO.md: The most detailed in the group. The Code section includes line-by-line *diffs*. However, the Examples section deviates from the REACTO format by including the full conversation with Copilot instead of program input/output examples. Stored in `brainsback/REACTO.md`.

Task 2 Artifacts: The only student to produce separate artifacts for Task 2: `brainsback/TODO_SCORE.md` (8 detailed steps including `localStorage`), `brainsback/REPORT_SCORE.md` and `brainsback/REACTO_SCORE.md`. The latter is exceptionally thorough, covering `localStorage` security vulnerabilities, race conditions with

multiple tabs, alternatives such as IndexedDB, and scalability analysis.

Socratic Review: Absent. No `socratic_review.md` or `copilot_conversation.md` in `artifacts/` or `brainsback/`.

Note: Despite the absence of a Socratic review, the depth of the SCORE artifacts suggests significant engagement — possibly guided by structured questions from a reviewer.

6.8 PR 6 — Participant 06 (Socratic)

TODO.md: Adequately structured with six steps (one duplicated), success criteria, and relevant notes on UTF-8 and string comparison. Covers only Task 1.

REACTO.md: All sections present but shallow — two to three sentences each. The Optimization section correctly identifies $O(1)$ complexity. Covers only Task 1.

Socratic Review: Complete (166 lines). Developer Profile: 3 years of experience; had previously implemented Tic-Tac-Toe. Revealed conceptual gaps: confused emojis with images (“to avoid loading problems, since an error could occur when loading the image”) and confused *front-end/back-end* (“index is the front-end and script.js is the back-end”). However, answered well on the i18n strategy.

Cognitive Debt Indicators: Moderate — short answers and conceptual gaps despite prior experience with the domain.

Delta note: Task 2 stayed slightly below Task 1 because the front-end/back-end confusion weakened module clarity, even though the product reasoning around the scoreboard was solid.

6.9 PR 7 — Participant 07 (Socratic)

TODO.md: Clean and well-written in English. Six logical steps from inspection to manual testing. Explicit constraint: “without changing game logic.” Notes correctly identify risk areas (internal victory logic, impacts on tests/rendering).

REACTO.md: Exceptional quality — the best REACTO in the batch. All sections well-developed with multiple paragraphs. The Approach demonstrates genuine decomposition of the problem into four parts (game logic, UI rendering, CSS styling, tests). The Code section explains the role and relationship of each file. Tests describe the real debugging journey (discovery and correction of the Unicode issue). Optimisation suggests a concrete future improvement (centralising mappings in a configuration object).

Copilot conversation: Model Claude Sonnet 4.5. Extensive conversation (453 lines). Honest and reflective student (“More or less. Should I explain?”).

Socratic Review: Complete (311 lines). Profile: 3 years of experience. Correct identification of changes in Task 1, partial confidence in debugging.

Comparative reflection: “In Task 1 I was more careful with the use of AI [...] I worked in a *pair programming* style. In the second task, since I had more freedom, I let the AI help me more, so it was much simpler and more practical.” — Key insight for research on *Cognitive Bypass*.

Cognitive debt indicators: Low in Task 1 (active engagement); higher in Task 2 (delegation).

Delta note: Task 2 dipped slightly because she relied more on AI, even though she could still explain the scoreboard design and rationale.

6.10 PR 9 — Participant 09 (Rejected)

Status: Rejected — required `socratic_review.md` is missing (only `socratic-review.md` is present), so the artifact naming rule is not satisfied.

TODO.md: Brief — only three steps, but naming specific functions (such as `createInitialState` and `getNextPlayer`). Minimal success criteria. Covers only Task 1.

REACTO.md: All sections present but brief (one to two sentences each). The Approach section admits direct use of Copilot for the changes. Optimization was dismissed as N/A. The shortest in the group.

Artifacts: Present but non-standard. The review file is `artifacts/socratic-review.md` instead of the required `artifacts/socratic_review.md`. The `artifacts/final-feedback.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md` are preserved in `artifacts/`. Note: the `copilot_conversation.md` is a chronological narrative summary generated by the agent rather than a raw interaction log; the `socraticreview.md` contains the five targeted Q&A questions conducted after Task 2.

Cognitive debt indicators: Not assessed (REJECTED due to missing required `socratic_review.md` filename). Observationally, the pipeline was followed for Task 1 (TODO.md and REACTO.md filled), but the REACTO is the shortest in the group and the Approach section explicitly admits direct Copilot delegation. The Task 2 Socratic review exists under a non-standard filename and covers only five targeted questions about score state management.

6.11 PR 11 — Participant 11 (Rejected)

Status: Rejected — missing `socratic_review.md` and `copilot_conversation.md`; Task 1 and Task 2 coverage cannot be verified.

Atypical case: All artifacts in `brainsback/` cover **Task 2** (scoreboard) instead of Task 1 (emojis). No artifact documents Task 1.

TODO.md (Task 2): Well structured with five steps, detailed success criteria (including edge cases such as draws, persistence, error handling for `localStorage`). Superior quality compared to several Task 1 TODO.md files.

REACTO.md (Task 2): Good quality with four examples covering normal flow, draws, error scenarios and *reset*. The Approach section describes a layered architecture.

Socratic Review: Completely absent. No `socratic_review.md` or `copilot_conversation.md` preserved.

Note: This raises the question: did the student completely skip Task 1 documentation, or complete it elsewhere? The quality of the Task 2 artifacts suggests engagement, but the reversal of artifacts is anomalous.

6.12 PR 12 — Participant 12 (Socratic)

TODO.md: Basic and clear, in English. Four steps focused on locating and replacing. User-centered success criteria (describe what the player sees).

REACTO.md: All sections present. Clean and concise, in English. The Code section lists specific changes by file. Approach is brief (one sentence). Average quality.

Conversation with Copilot: Model Claude Haiku 4.5. The student is notably honest: “To be honest I have no idea” (about why the *spread operator* is needed for emojis). For Task 2: “I don’t feel confident, because I have no experience with JavaScript and HTML.”

Socratic Review: Complete (112 lines). Developer Profile: 3 years of experience, but very little in JavaScript. Task 1: good high-level understanding, acknowledged gap in Unicode handling. Task 2: low confidence in debugging, explanation, and sustainability — “It would require more time to study [...] I might have to rewrite it from scratch.”

Cognitive Debt Indicators: Clear contrast — Task 1 understood, Task 2 dependent on AI.

6.13 PR 13 — Participant 13 (Socratic)

TODO.md: Contains an introductory paragraph before the *template* structure that reads like an AI instruction. Very generic steps (“remove old markers”, “add new ones”). Explicitly emphasizes “ONLY the visual field.”

REACTO.md: All sections present but brief. The Approach stands out: explicit strategy of modifying only visual files to avoid logic conflicts. Names specific functions created (`toVisualMarker`, `formatTurnStatus`, `formatWinnerStatus`).

Architectural Note: Implemented a visual mapping layer in `script.js`, but the core game state in `game.js` uses emojis directly, so the logic is emoji-first with compatibility mapping in the UI.

Socratic Review: Complete (104 lines). Developer Profile: 2 years of experience, widest variety of AI tools (Claude, GPT, Gemini, GROK). Task 1: good understanding of the presentation/logic separation, but unable to explain module structure. Task 2: “Can you explain the components without looking at the code? — No”; “Can you debug a critical scoreboard error without AI? — I think most likely no.”

Cognitive Debt Indicators: High in Task 2. Notable honesty about limitations.

6.14 PR 14 — Participant 14 (Socratic)

TODO.md: Written in Spanish (Spanish-speaking student). Concise and well-structured with three clear steps and concrete success criteria. Correctly identifies the files to be modified in the notes.

REACTO.md: All sections covered with concrete examples, including a draw scenario. The Approach correctly identifies the dictionary strategy in the presentation layer, without modifying the internal logic.

Task 2 Artifacts: One of the few students to produce separate documentation — `REPORT-scoring.md` describes the scoreboard implementation with `scoreX/score0` in the game state.

Socratic Review: Complete. Developer Profile: 4 years of experience. Model: Claude Haiku. For Task 1, demonstrated good understanding of the logic/presentation separation. For Task 2, admitted: “just let it do it” when asked to explain module interactions. Could not explain the implementation without studying the code first.

Cognitive Debt Indicators: Clear gap between Task 1 (understood) and Task 2 (delegated to AI).

6.15 PR 15 — Participant 15 (Rejected)

Status: Rejected — missing required artifacts (`artifacts/socratic_review.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md`).

TODO.md: Sparse — the “Success Looks Like” and “Notes” sections were mostly left empty. Three generic steps. Below average in detail.

REACTO.md: Detailed and conversational. Correctly describes the creation of a mapping dictionary in `game.js` for use in `script.js`. Extensive manual tests (diagonal, vertical, horizontal for each player).

Socratic Review: Located in `brainsback/SOCRATIC_REVIEW.md` (non-standard location). Table-format review with eight questions covering both tasks, all approved. Student demonstrated spontaneous architectural reasoning (questioned the `PLAYER_SYMBOLS` design decision unprompted) and correctly identified Unicode risks and separation-of-concerns principles for both tasks. Growth area identified: initial confusion between the T and O sections of the REACTO.

Cognitive debt indicators: Not scored due to missing required artifacts. The non-standard Socratic review suggests understanding of both tasks, but the absence of `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md` prevents assessing delegation patterns.

Literal Transcript of the Socratic Review (`brainsback/SOCRATIC_REVIEW.md`):

```
--- socratic_review.md ---

# Socratic Review Report

**Date:** 2026-04-16
**Reviewer:** GitHub Copilot
**Tasks:** Task 1 - Symbol replacement with emoji | Task 2 - Scoreboard

## Result: :white-check-mark: APPROVED

## Questions & Assessment

| # | Task | Topic | Assessment |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | T1 | Why `PLAYER_SYMBOLS` is in `game.js` | :white-check-mark: Demonstrated own reasoning and
↳ questioned the decision |
| 2 | T1 | Why keep internal tokens `X`/'O' | :white-check-mark: Identified Unicode risk and
↳ maintainability |
| 3 | T1 | How the solution was tested | :white-check-mark: Manual tests (all win combinations) +
↳ automated |
| 4 | T1 | Role of `render`, `handleClick`, `restartGame` | :white-check-mark: Explained the flow
↳ correctly |
| 5 | T1 | Where to change the symbol if needed | :white-check-mark: Pointed directly to `PLAYER_SYMBOLS`
↳ in `game.js` |
| 6 | T2 | Separation of responsibilities (`updateScore` in `game.js`) | :white-check-mark: Correctly
↳ identified the principle |
| 7 | T2 | Decision to persist scoreboard between games | :white-check-mark: Consciously justified |
| 8 | T2 | Memory limits and session persistence | :white-check-mark: Described `localStorage` and UX
↳ correctly |

## Notes
- Candidate demonstrated understanding of separation between logic and presentation in both tasks.
- Reasoning about UX (not forcing unwanted behavior) was spontaneous and mature.

**:green-circle: Ready for PR.**
--- copilot_conversation.md ---

[Missing: `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md` not found in this repository.]
```

6.16 PR 16 — Participant 16 (Missing Socratic)

Status: Rejected — missing required artifacts (`artifacts/socratic_review.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md`).

TODO.md: Naive find-and-replace approach: “Search for X everywhere in the code [...] Replace with the emoji.” Reflects limited architectural thinking.

REACTO.md: Honest: explicitly admits that “I did not describe the necessary

logical changes but the agent handled it anyway.” The Optimization section demonstrates good insight about centralizing symbols for future maintainability.

Implementation approach: Modified the internal game state to use emojis directly (unlike the majority who used a display layer), requiring extensive modifications to tests.

Socratic Review: Completely absent. No conversation or review preserved. Only Task 1 was completed.

Cognitive debt indicators: The admission of delegation to the agent suggests significant cognitive debt, but cannot be quantified without a Socratic review.

6.17 PR 17 — Participant 17 (Socratic)

TODO.md: Minimal — three generic steps with no detail whatsoever: “Remove traditional symbols”, “Insert new symbols”, “Update the test cases.”

REACTO.md: Good quality despite the weak TODO. The R acknowledges that the change “is not merely visual, but affects the entire codebase.” The Approach describes a full sweep updating state, logic, DOM, CSS, and tests. Complexity analyzed as unchanged (fixed 3×3 board).

Socratic Review: Complete (64 lines in `copilot_conversation.md`). Developer Profile: 3 years of experience, had previously implemented Tic-Tac-Toe. Admitted twice that he cannot debug without AI at 2 a.m. Correctly identified that the scoreboard has no cap (“the user will keep playing and accumulating points forever”).

Comparative Reflection: “In both tasks Copilot was fast and accurate. I think for more complex tasks the first approach would be better because it is more step-by-step.”

Cognitive Debt Indicators: Moderate to high — correct high-level answers, but mislocated the scoreboard state in Task 2 and admitted dependency on AI for debugging.

6.18 PR 18 — Participant 18 (Socratic)

TODO.md: Good. With *checkmarks* showing completion tracking. Four steps including verification that `checkWinner` works correctly. Covers task 1.

REACTO.md: Strong. Approach clearly articulates the logic/visualisation separation with a mapping dictionary. Optimisation mentions visual translation in $O(1)$. Demonstrates understanding of separation of responsibilities.

Copilot conversation: Model Cursor Auto / GPT-5.2. **Most engaged student in the group** — actively directed the AI instead of being directed: “I want to take a look in the codebase [...] Analyze TODO.md to ensure you understand what our issue is. Then tell me what are the main files we will need to change.” Chose the strategy: “I agree with the strategy to keep the backend logic with X and O.” For task 2, found and navigated the pipeline rules (`pipeline.sh OFF`).

Socratic Review: Very complete (153 lines). Excellent explanation of modules, decoupling between `game.js` and `script.js`. For task 2, described the scoreboard flow and the `gameOver` guard, but initially placed score state in `game.js` rather than `script.js`.

Comparative reflection: “Task 1 requires more time (TODO/REACTO), but gives better understanding; task 2 is faster but more passive and can be costly later.” — Metacognitive observation about cognitive debt.

Cognitive debt indicators: Low in task 1; slightly higher in task 2 due to the scoreboard state confusion, despite otherwise strong engagement.

6.19 PR 19 — Participant 19 (Rejected)

TODO.md: Good. Notable criterion: “There is no hard coded emoji” — demonstrates awareness of abstraction in planning. Six steps from analysis to test updates.

REACTO.md: Sparse — Approach summarized in one line (“centralize symbol usage with domain constants”), Code section mentions only the function. Optimization discusses memory allocation (tangential to the context).

Copilot Conversation: Model GPT-5.3-Codex. **More automated approach** — only four *prompts* to complete both tasks. Comprehensive instructions in a single message: “Implement emoji replacement with software engineering principles.”

Socratic Review: Incomplete (63 lines) — covered only the Task 2 debate with three questions, with no Task 1 Socratic debate. This violates the study rule requiring both tasks, so the PR is classified as REJECTED.

Cognitive Debt Indicators: Not scored due to rejection; the *hands-off* approach (4 prompts) still indicates high delegation risk.

6.20 PR 20 — Participant 20 (Socratic)

TODO.md: Concise but minimal — three steps for task 1 with no detail on approach (internal vs. presentation). No coverage of task 2, despite having implemented it.

REACTO.md: All sections for task 1. The Approach describes a parameterized function (`replaceSymbol`) that receives symbols as an argument. The Code section names specific functions (`replaceSymbol`, `replaceSymbols`). Optimization proposes internalizing the symbols configuration.

Copilot Conversation: Model GPT-4.1. Structured Socratic dialogue of 92 lines. Coverage of both tasks.

Socratic Review: Complete (78 lines). Developer Profile: 4 years of experience. Good architectural reasoning (MVC separation, testing strategies).

Comparative Reflection: “In both tasks I felt I knew practically nothing about the code and was just guiding the AI based on what seemed to make sense, but in task 1 thanks to the TODO.md I found it easier to know what to do and where to start, even though task 2 was good for offering more freedom.” — Notably honest.

Cognitive Debt Indicators: Moderate in both tasks; the TODO.md provided guiding structure in task 1, while the participant still reported limited ownership of the code.

Note: This is the third PR from the same student in the *dataset* (also has PR 8 and PR 10).

6.21 PR 21 — Participant 21 (Socratic)

Literal Transcript of the Socratic Review and Copilot Conversation:

```
# Socratic Review - TicTacToe Experiment

## AI Model

GPT-5.3-Codex

## Initial Autonomous Verification of the Code

- Task 1 (emojis): **completed**.
- Evidence in the code:
  - `game.js`: constants `PLAYER_X_ICON = ':cat-face:'` and `PLAYER_O_ICON = ':dog-face:'`.
```

```

- `script.js`: rendering and status use `getPlayerIcon(...)`.
```

- Task 2 (scoreboard): **completed**.

- Evidence in the code:

```

- `game.js`: `createInitialScore()` and `addWin(...)`.
- `script.js`: state `score`, call to `addWin(...)` on victory and `renderScore()` updating the DOM.
- `index.html`: elements `score-cat` and `score-dog`.
```

Initial Profile Questions

1) How many years of programming experience do you have?

- Answer: **4 years**

2) Have you used code assistants before? Which one(s)?

- Answer: **yes, gpt, gemini, copilot and claude**

3) Had you programmed tic-tac-toe before?

- Answer: **no**

4) What LLM model did you use during the process?

- Answer: **gpt 5.3-codex**

Part A - Review of Task 1 (Emojis)

1) What was implemented in Task 1?

- Answer: **the replacement of the x and o icons with cat and dog**

- Evaluation: aligned with the functional requirement.

2) Module explanation without looking at the code

- Answer: **no**

- Evaluation: indicates a gap in structural explainability.

3) Debugging autonomy without AI

- Answer: **yes**

- Evaluation: positive perception of operational autonomy.

4) Logic justification

- Answer: **yes**

- Evaluation: claims understanding of why the implementation was done this way.

5) Onboarding capability

- Answer: **yes**

- Evaluation: indicates knowledge transfer capability.

6) Sustainability without AI

- Answer: **yes**

- Evaluation: indicates perceived maintainability without AI dependency.

7) Satisfaction with the result

- Answer: **yes**

- Evaluation: overall positive satisfaction.

Socratic Debate - Task 1

Technical Question 1

If the player-to-emoji mapping function returned X/O instead of emoji, what symptoms would appear first?

- Answer: **the error would appear in game.js itself, the primary symptom would be the difference in the**
↳ **interface**

- Technical evaluation:

- Correct about the primary UI symptom.
- Conceptual adjustment: it would be a presentation regression, not necessarily an execution error of
↳ the engine.

Technical Question 2

If you needed to change emojis in the future, what single point of change would you choose?

- Answer: ****I would only change the variable that defines what emoji each player uses, to avoid changes ↪ to the logic****
- Technical evaluation:
 - Excellent. Consistent strategy with low coupling.
 - Coherent with centralized icon constants.

Part B - Review of Task 2 (Score)

1) What was implemented in Task 2?

- Answer: ****the scoring system for the cat and the dog****
- Evaluation: aligned with the task's objective.

2) Module explanation without looking at the code

- Answer: ****yes****
- Evaluation: self-perception of structural understanding.

3) Debugging autonomy without AI

- Answer: ****yes****
- Evaluation: positive self-perception of autonomy.

4) Logic justification

- Answer: ****yes****
- Evaluation: declared understanding of why the solution was designed this way.

5) Onboarding capability

- Answer: ****no****
- Evaluation: indicates a point of improvement in technical communication of the design.

6) Sustainability without AI

- Answer: ****yes****
- Evaluation: perception of maintainability without AI.

7) Satisfaction with the result

- Answer: ****yes****
- Evaluation: positive satisfaction with the deliverable.

Socratic Debate - Task 2

Technical Question 1

At what exact moment of the flow should the score be incremented to prevent invalid counting?

- Answer: ****it should be incremented only at the end of the match. This is safer because a click could be ↪ exploited if the user deliberately clicks many times****
- Technical evaluation:
 - Correct. Incrementing after a confirmed victory prevents counting from click attempts.

Technical Question 2

When clicking New Game, should the scoreboard reset or stay accumulated?

- Answer: ****reset, because it would be a new game****
- Technical evaluation:
 - Diverges from the current implementation.
 - The current implementation keeps it accumulated between rounds and only resets the board/turn.

Final Comparative Reflection

Question: how do you feel about Task 1 compared to Task 2 (pros and cons)?

- Answer:

```

- **Pros of Task 1:** AI more directed by the pipeline.
- **Cons of Task 1:** additional bureaucracy from the pipeline and method.
- **Pros of Task 2:** faster without needing multiple documents.
- **Cons of Task 2:** AI much freer, which can diverge if the prompt is not good.

## Consent Verification

- Verified file: `artifacts/consentimento.md`
- Required fields found:
  - Registration number: **REDACTED**
  - Name: **Participant 21**
  - Explicit consent: **Yes**
- Status: **valid**

## Conclusion

- Socratic review completed successfully.
- Both tasks implemented in the code.
- Consent filled in correctly.
- Final result communicated to the developer: **everything ready for the PR**.

--- copilot_conversation.md ---

# Transcript of the conversation - Socratic Review Session

## AI Model

GPT-5.3-Codex

## Transcript

**User:** I want to start the Socratic review.

**Copilot:** Autonomous verification completed: both tasks are already implemented in the code. (...) Let
↳ us start the Socratic review. 1. How many years of programming experience do you have?

**User:** 4 years

**Copilot:** 2. Have you used code assistants before? Which one(s)?

**User:** yes, gpt, gemini, copilot and claude

**Copilot:** 3. Had you programmed tic-tac-toe before?

**User:** no

**Copilot:** 4. What LLM model did you use during the process (e.g.: Claude Haiku, Gemini 3.1 Pro)?

**User:** gpt 5.3-codex

**Copilot:** Perfect. Let us move to Part A (Task 1 - Emojis). 1. What was implemented in Task 1?

**User:** the replacement of the x and o icons with cat and dog

**Copilot:** 2. Module explanation: can you explain how the modified or created components interact with
↳ each other without looking at the source code?

**User:** no

**Copilot:** 3. Debugging autonomy: do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this
↳ implementation at 2 a.m. without AI assistance?

**User:** yes

**Copilot:** 4. Logic justification: do you understand why this implementation was done this way and not
↳ another?

**User:** yes

**Copilot:** 5. Onboarding capability: if a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the
↳ internal logic of this feature without them having to read every line generated by AI?

**User:** yes

```

****Copilot:**** 6. Sustainability without AI: would the code for this task remain maintainable by you if AI
↳ tools ceased to exist today?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** 7. Were you satisfied with the result of Task 1?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** Socratic debate for Task 1, technical question 1: If the player-to-emoji mapping function
↳ returned the original value (X/0) instead of the emoji, what symptoms would you see first in the
↳ interface and which parts of the flow would show it?

****User:**** the error would appear in game.js itself, the primary symptom would be the difference in the
↳ interface

****Copilot:**** Good answer (...) Socratic debate for Task 1, technical question 2: If you had to change the
↳ emojis again in the future, what single point of change would you choose to avoid scattered changes
↳ in the project, and why?

****User:**** I would only change the variable that says what emoji each player uses, to avoid changes to the
↳ logic

****Copilot:**** Excellent answer (...) Let us move to Part B (Task 2 - Score). 1. What was implemented in
↳ Task 2?

****User:**** the scoring system for the cat and the dog

****Copilot:**** 2. Module explanation: can you explain how the modified or created components interact in
↳ Task 2, without looking at the source code?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** 3. Debugging autonomy: do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in the scoreboard
↳ implementation at 2 a.m. without AI assistance?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** 4. Logic justification: do you understand why the scoreboard implementation was done this
↳ way and not another?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** 5. Onboarding capability: if a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the
↳ internal logic of the scoreboard without them needing to read every line generated by AI?

****User:**** no

****Copilot:**** 6. Sustainability without AI: would the Task 2 code remain maintainable by you if AI tools
↳ ceased to exist today?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** 7. Were you satisfied with the result of Task 2?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** Socratic debate for Task 2, technical question 1: At what exact moment in the flow of a
↳ match should the score be incremented to avoid invalid counting, and why is this safer than
↳ incrementing on the cell click?

****User:**** it should be incremented only at the end of the match. this is safer because a click could be
↳ exploited if the user deliberately clicks many times

****Copilot:**** Great answer (...) Socratic debate for Task 2, technical question 2: If the user clicks New
↳ Game, what is the correct scoreboard behavior: reset or keep the accumulated score? Justify based on
↳ the goal of the score feature.

****User:**** reset, because it would be a new game

****Copilot:**** Good answer, but it diverges from the behavior implemented today (...) Final comparative
↳ reflection: How do you feel about Task 1 compared to Task 2? List pros and cons of each.

****User:**** pros of task 1: the AI seemed more directed because of the pipeline used
cons: lots of bureaucracy because of the pipeline and AI methods

pros of task 2: faster because there are no multiple documents to fill out etc
cons: AI much freer, which can diverge from the expected result if I do not make a GOOD prompt

****Copilot:**** Thank you for participating (...) everything is ready for the PR.

****User:**** can you generate the files

****Copilot:**** Files generated in `artifacts/`.

****Copilot:**** Autonomous verification completed: both tasks are already implemented in the code. (...) Let
↳ us start the Socratic review. 1. How many years of programming experience do you have?

****User:**** 4 years

****Copilot:**** 2. Have you used code assistants before? Which one(s)?

****User:**** yes, gpt, gemini, copilot and claude

****Copilot:**** 3. Had you programmed tic-tac-toe before?

****User:**** no

****Copilot:**** 4. What LLM model did you use during the process (e.g.: Claude Haiku, Gemini 3.1 Pro)?

****User:**** gpt 5.3-codex

****Copilot:**** Perfect. Let us move to Part A (Task 1 - Emojis). 1. What was implemented in Task 1?

****User:**** the replacement of the x and o icons with cat and dog

****Copilot:**** 2. Module explanation: can you explain how the altered or created components interact with
↳ each other without looking at the source code?

****User:**** no

****Copilot:**** 3. Debugging autonomy: do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this
↳ implementation at two in the morning without AI assistance?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** 4. Logic justification: do you understand why this implementation was done this way and not
↳ another?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** 5. Onboarding capability: if a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the
↳ internal logic of this feature without them needing to read every line generated by AI?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** 6. Sustainability without AI: would the code of this task remain maintainable by you if AI
↳ tools stopped existing today?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** 7. Were you satisfied with the result of Task 1?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** Socratic debate of Task 1, technical question 1: If the player-to-emoji mapping function
↳ returned the original value (X/O) instead of the emoji, what symptoms would you see first in the
↳ interface and in which parts of the flow would this appear?

****User:**** the error would appear in game.js itself, the primary symptom would be the difference in the
↳ interface

****Copilot:**** Good answer (...) Socratic debate of Task 1, technical question 2: If you had to change the
↳ emojis again in the future, what single point of change would you choose to avoid changes spread
↳ throughout the project, and why?

****User:**** I would only change the variable that defines what emoji each player uses, to avoid changes to
↳ the logic

****Copilot:**** Excellent answer (...) Let us move to Part B (Task 2 - Score). 1. What was implemented in
↳ Task 2?

****User:**** the scoring system for the cat and the dog

****Copilot:**** 2. Module explanation: can you explain how the altered or created components interact with
↳ each other in Task 2, without looking at the source code?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** 3. Debugging autonomy: do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this scoreboard
↳ implementation at two in the morning without AI assistance?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** 4. Logic justification: do you understand why the scoreboard implementation was done this
↳ way and not another?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** 5. Onboarding capability: if a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the
↳ internal logic of the scoreboard without them needing to read every line generated by AI?

****User:**** no

****Copilot:**** 6. Sustainability without AI: would the code of Task 2 remain maintainable by you if AI
↳ tools stopped existing today?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** 7. Were you satisfied with the result of Task 2?

****User:**** yes

****Copilot:**** Great answer (...) Socratic debate of Task 2, technical question 1: At what exact moment of
↳ the match flow should the score be incremented to avoid invalid counting, and why is this point safer
↳ than incrementing on the cell click?

****User:**** it should be incremented only at the end of the match. This is safer because a click could be
↳ exploited if the user deliberately clicks many times

****Copilot:**** Great answer (...) Socratic debate of Task 2, technical question 2: If the user clicks New
↳ Game, what is the correct behaviour for the scoreboard: reset or keep the accumulated score? Justify
↳ based on the objective of the score feature.

****User:**** reset, because it would be a new game

****Copilot:**** Good answer, but it diverges from the currently implemented behaviour (...) Final
↳ comparative reflection question: How do you feel about the implementation of Task 1 compared to Task
↳ 2? Cite pros and cons of each one.

****User:**** Pros of Task 1: the AI seemed more directed due to the pipeline used.
Cons: lots of bureaucracy required because of the pipeline and methods with the AI.

Pros of Task 2: faster because there was no need to fill in multiple documents, etc.
Cons: AI much freer, which can diverge from the expected result if I do not make a GOOD prompt.

****Copilot:**** Thank you for your participation (...) everything is ready for the PR.

****User:**** please generate the files

****Copilot:**** Files generated in `artifacts/`.

6.22 PR 22 — Participant 22 (Missing Socratic)

TODO.md: Best TODO in the group — the only one covering both tasks in separate sections. Task 1 with three steps including visual compatibility. Task 2 with four steps including persistence and outcome identification. The Task 2 notes raise a design question: “Define whether draws affect the score or not.”

REACTO.md: Stark contrast with the TODO — it is the weakest in the group. Only Task 1, no function names (typographical error: “scripst.js”), only manual tests mentioned. One sentence for Optimization.

Status: REJECTED — missing `artifacts/socratic_review.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversations.md`.

Socratic Review: Absent. No conversation or review preserved.

Note: The contrast between the TODO quality (best in the group) and the REACTO (weakest in the group) suggests that the student invested in the formal specification but not in the post-implementation proof of mastery — possibly indicating that understanding did not follow the specification.

6.23 PR 23 — Participant 23 (Missing Socratic)

TODO.md: Good for Task 1 with all *checkboxes* marked as completed. Three clear steps. No coverage of Task 2.

REACTO.md: Strongest REACTO for Task 1. Functional-level detail: names each function, file and specific change. The Approach section explains the key technical challenge (`toLowerCase()` does not work on emojis) and the solution (`getPlayerClass`). Tests list 31/31 automated + five manual scenarios.

Model used: Grok Code Fast 1 (not GitHub Copilot) — the only student using an alternative model.

Additional artifact: `relatorio_final.md` — a final report written by the student (not AI-generated) covering both tasks with detailed analysis, lessons learned and reflections on AI. Key quote: “Using AI can lead to less deep understanding if you don’t reflect; the pipeline forced reflection.”

Status: REJECTED — missing `artifacts/socratic_review.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversations.md`.

Socratic Review: Formally absent, but `relatorio_final.md` functions as a self-reflective substitute.

Cognitive debt indicators: The final report demonstrates significant reflective engagement.

6.24 PR 24 — Participant 24 (Missing Socratic)

TODO.md: Good, written in English. Noteworthy is the notes section with prior architectural thinking: “Keeping X and O in the internal logic and changing only the UI should make the change safer and easier to test later.” — A rare example of a design decision documented *before* implementation.

REACTO.md: Second strongest REACTO. All sections well developed. The Approach articulates the display-layer strategy with clear reasoning. The Code section describes the flow (`handleClick` → state update → `render`). The Optimization section discusses the *trade-off*: an extra mapping layer adds flexibility for future changes.

Status: REJECTED — missing `artifacts/socratic_review.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversations.md`.

Socratic Review: Absent. No conversation or review.

Task 2 artifacts: Completely absent. Task 2 may not have been implemented.

Cognitive debt indicators: Not assessable without a Socratic review, but artifact quality suggests solid cognitive engagement in Task 1.

6.25 PR 25 — Participant 25 (Socratic)

TODO.md: Focused and concise for Task 1 (emoji replacement), with an explicit guardrail: avoid globally replacing X/O. Good strategic constraint.

REACTO.md: Mixed quality. The implementation idea is correct (mapping helper and presentation-layer conversion), but documentation quality is uneven, with language issues and incomplete Optimization.

Status: SOCRATIC.

Socratic Review: Present and extensive. The participant shows strong reflective maturity (explicitly warning about “vibe coding”), high autonomy, and good understanding after guided questioning.

Cognitive debt indicators: Low to Medium. Initial explanations were sometimes shallow, but the Socratic process produced clear self-correction and architectural understanding.

6.26 PR 26 — Participant 26 (Missing Socratic)

Status: Rejected — missing required artifacts (`artifacts/socratic_review.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md`).

TODO.md: Basic checklist template, partially generic. Includes expected outcomes and test update intent, but remains shallow.

REACTO.md: Structurally complete for Task 1, including mapping function and tests. However, evidence is narrowly scoped and no Socratic validation exists.

Socratic Review: Absent.

Consent artifact: Filled with explicit consent (“Sim”).

Cognitive debt indicators: High. Without Socratic artifacts and with incomplete consent metadata, mastery cannot be validated robustly.

Literal Transcript of the Socratic Review and Copilot Conversation:

```
--- socratic_review.md ---  
[Missing: `artifacts/socratic_review.md` not found in this repository.]  
  
--- copilot_conversation.md ---  
[Missing: `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md` not found in this repository.]
```

6.27 PR 27 — Participant 27 (Missing Socratic)

Status: Rejected — missing required artifacts (`artifacts/socratic_review.md` and `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md`).

TODO.md: Operationally detailed, including process friction and test-runner workarounds.

REACTO.md: Covers changes and tests with traceability, but writing quality and conceptual precision vary.

Copilot conversation: No conversation artifact preserved.

Socratic Review: Absent.

Comparative Reflection: No final comparative reflection artifact generated via Socratic workflow.

Cognitive Debt Indicators: Medium to High.

Literal Transcript of the Socratic Review and Copilot Conversation:

```
--- socratic_review.md ---  
[Missing: `artifacts/socratic_review.md` not found in this repository.]  
--- copilot_conversation.md ---  
[Missing: `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md` not found in this repository.]
```

6.28 PR 28 — Participant 28 (Socratic)

TODO.md: Clear and procedural. Includes explicit read/locate/change/test sequence and aligns with the delivered artifacts.

REACTO.md: Solid for Task 1 with concrete behavior examples and clear separation between domain logic and UI mapping.

Socratic Review: Present and coherent for both Task 1 and Task 2. The participant reports strong autonomy and gives technically consistent answers on scoreboard persistence and update flow.

Comparative reflection: Strongly favors Task 1 for learning retention due to the guided artifact process; reports lower depth in the less-guided Task 2.

Cognitive debt indicators: Medium. Good technical command, but self-reported reduction in deep understanding when guidance is reduced.

Literal Transcript of the Socratic Artifacts:

```
--- brainsback/TODO.md ---  
# Strategic Blueprint  
  
> Focus on the what and why. The code will follow.  
  
Hard rule: AI agents must not edit this file and must not draft paste-ready content for it.  
  
## The Problem  
The index.html file features a game of tic-tac-toe. I need to swap the Xs in the game with cat face  
↪ emojis for me and the Os with dog face emojis.  
  
## Steps  
- [ ] Read the relevant files (Start with index.html, game.js and script.js)  
- [ ] Find the part of the code which is relevant to solve the problem  
- [ ] Make the necessary changes  
--- socratic_review.md ---  
# Socratic Review  
  
AI Model: GPT-5.2-Codex  
Date: 2026-04-29  
  
## Task Verification  
- Task 1 (Emojis): completed. Interface displays :cat-face:/:dog-face: and logic continues with X/O.  
- Task 2 (Score): completed. Scoreboard increments wins and updates interface.  
  
## Initial Profile  
Question 1: How much programming experience do you have?  
Answer: 9 years of professional programming experience  
  
Question 2: Have you used coding assistants before? Which one(s)?  
Answer: In agent mode I have used Cursor and Copilot. But I have also used ChatGPT and Gemini for  
↪ general code generation.
```

```

**Question 3:** Had you programmed tic-tac-toe before?
**Answer:** At the start of my undergraduate studies, 11 years ago, I made a very simple one

**Question 4:** What LLM model did you use during the process (e.g., Claude Haiku, Gemini 3.1 Pro
↳ Preview)?
**Answer:** GPT-5.2-Codex

---

# Part A - Task 1 (Emojis)

## Reflective Review
**Question 1:** What was implemented in Task 1?
**Answer:** A change that visually altered the player representation in the game from X to cat emojis and
↳ O to dog emoji.
**Technical Assessment:** Correct and consistent with the interface behavior.

**Question 2:** Can you explain how the altered or created components interact with each other without
↳ looking at the source code?
**Answer:** The index.html loads both JS files. In script.js the model created a mapping that translated
↳ from the old representation to the new one, and a function to retrieve from this mapping. All calls
↳ to setStatus, which changed this representation in the interface, were updated to use this new
↳ function.
**Technical Assessment:** Correct; the mapping is used in board rendering and status.

**Question 3:** Do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this implementation at 2 AM without
↳ AI tools?
**Answer:** Yes
**Technical Assessment:** Consistent with the simplicity of the change.

**Question 4:** Do you understand the fundamental reason behind this specific implementation choice (the
↳ "why" of being this way and not another)?
**Answer:** Yes
**Technical Assessment:** No conflict with the implementation.

**Question 5:** If a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the internal logic of this
↳ feature without them needing to read every AI-generated line?
**Answer:** Yes
**Technical Assessment:** Plausible given the central location of the mapping.

**Question 6:** Would the code of this task remain perfectly maintainable by you if AI tools ceased to
↳ exist today?
**Answer:** Yes
**Technical Assessment:** Plausible.

**Question 7:** Were you satisfied with the result?
**Answer:** Yes
**Technical Assessment:** No inconsistencies.

## Socratic Debate
**Question 1:** At which points of the interface was the symbol substitution applied, and why was it not
↳ necessary to change the central game logic?
**Answer:** In the text above the game showing which is the current player and in the board squares.
**Technical Assessment:** Partial; the scoreboard labels were not mentioned. The central logic retained
↳ X/O and the presentation layer simply translates to emojis, avoiding changes to the game engine.

**Question 2:** If you wanted to swap the emojis again in the future, what would be the single point of
↳ change and why does this choice reduce regression risk?
**Answer:** The mapping object would be the single point of change. It reduces regression risk because
↳ the logic itself would not need to change, only the character going to the interface.
**Technical Assessment:** Correct; centralization reduces the surface area of change.

---

# Part B - Task 2 (Score)

## Reflective Review
**Question 1:** What was implemented in Task 2?
**Answer:** A scoreboard to track each player's wins.
**Technical Assessment:** Correct; there is scoreboard state and rendering.

**Question 2:** Can you explain how the altered or created components interact with each other without
↳ looking at the source code?

```

```

**Answer:** Yes, but more vaguely than in Task 1. Similarly to Task 1, the model altered the HTML that
↳ loads the .js files. In the HTML the initial scoreboard state was added. In script.js the win
↳ tracking was added and an updateScoreboard function that is used at the end of the game to update the
↳ scoreboard logic.
**Technical Assessment:** Essentially correct; the update occurs on win and in the initial render.

**Question 3:** Do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this implementation at 2 AM without
↳ AI tools?
**Answer:** Yes, but because the task was relatively simple
**Technical Assessment:** Plausible.

**Question 4:** Do you understand the fundamental reason behind this specific implementation choice (the
↳ "why" of being this way and not another)?
**Answer:** Yes
**Technical Assessment:** No conflict with the implementation.

**Question 5:** If a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the internal logic of this
↳ feature without them needing to read every AI-generated line?
**Answer:** Yes
**Technical Assessment:** Plausible; the separation between state and rendering is simple.

**Question 6:** Would the code of this task remain perfectly maintainable by you if AI tools ceased to
↳ exist today?
**Answer:** Yes
**Technical Assessment:** Plausible.

## Socratic Debate
**Question 1:** At exactly what point in the game flow is the scoreboard updated, and why does this place
↳ avoid duplicate counts?
**Answer:** Only at initial state generation and at the end of the game (and only if there is a winner).
↳ Since this only happens in gameOver state, everything is blocked and no new results can be counted
↳ until a new game is started.
**Technical Assessment:** Correct; the increment only occurs when there is a winner and the game enters
↳ gameOver.

**Question 2:** Why is the scoreboard not reset when the player clicks "New Game", and what would need to
↳ change to reset the scoreboard along with the board?
**Answer:** It is not reset because the scores object is global and is not part of the initial state
↳ initialization. For it to be reset along with the board, it would need to be added to the state
↳ object that is generated when clicking the new game button
**Technical Assessment:** Correct; resetting would require reassigning scores on reset or moving it to
↳ the initial state.

---

# Final Comparative Reflection
**Question:** How do you feel about the implementation of Task 1 compared to Task 2? State the pros and
↳ cons of each.
**Answer:** In Task 1, due to the process, I ended up paying more attention to the details of what was
↳ implemented, both before needing to write the .md document and during the writing (which forced me to
↳ look more deeply). In Task 2, since the task was less guided, I only reviewed the code as it was
↳ suggested and did not look more deeply afterward, which hindered understanding.
**Technical Assessment:** Reflection consistent with the level of detail observed in the responses.

--- copilot_conversation.md ---
**AI Model:** GPT-5.2-Codex

**Transcript:**
**User:** I want to start the Socratic review
**Copilot:** Perfect, let's start the Socratic review.

First question: how much programming experience do you have?

**User:** 9 years of professional programming experience
**Copilot:** Thank you. Have you used coding assistants before? Which one(s)?

**User:** In agent mode I have used Cursor and Copilot. But I have also used ChatGPT and Gemini for
↳ general code generation.
**Copilot:** Thank you. Had you programmed tic-tac-toe before?

**User:** At the start of my undergraduate studies, 11 years ago, I made a very simple one
**Copilot:** Thank you. What LLM model did you use during the process (e.g., Claude Haiku, Gemini 3.1 Pro
↳ Preview)?

```

****User:**** GPT-5.2-Codex
****Copilot:**** Part A (Task 1 - Emojis): what was implemented in Task 1?

****User:**** A change that visually altered the player representation in the game from X to cat emojis and O
↳ to dog emoji.
****Copilot:**** Part A (Task 1 - Emojis): can you explain how the altered or created components interact
↳ with each other without looking at the source code?

****User:**** The index.html loads both JS files. In script.js the model created a mapping that translated
↳ from the old representation to the new one, and a function to retrieve from this mapping. All calls
↳ to setStatus, which changed this representation in the interface, were updated to use this new
↳ function.
****Copilot:**** Part A (Task 1 - Emojis): do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this
↳ implementation at 2 AM without AI tools?

****User:**** Yes
****Copilot:**** Part A (Task 1 - Emojis): do you understand the fundamental reason behind this specific
↳ implementation choice (the "why" of being this way and not another)?

****User:**** Yes
****Copilot:**** Part A (Task 1 - Emojis): if a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the
↳ internal logic of this feature without them needing to read every AI-generated line?

****User:**** Yes
****Copilot:**** Part A (Task 1 - Emojis): would the code of this task remain perfectly maintainable by you
↳ if AI tools ceased to exist today?

****User:**** Yes
****Copilot:**** Part A (Task 1 - Emojis) - Socratic debate, question 1: at which points of the interface was
↳ the symbol substitution applied, and why was it not necessary to change the central game logic?

****User:**** In the text above the game showing which is the current player and in the board squares.
****Copilot:**** Your answer covers two key points: the turn status and the board squares. This is consistent
↳ with the use of `getPlayerLabel()` in script.js. You did not mention that the scoreboard in the
↳ interface also shows emojis in labels, defined in index.html. The central logic did not need to
↳ change because the game state continues using `X`/`O` in game.js, with only the presentation layer
↳ translating to emojis.

Before moving to the second debate question, were you satisfied with the result?

****User:**** That question about the scoreboard refers to Task 2, that's why I didn't mention it.
****Copilot:**** Good observation about the scoreboard being linked to Task 2. Still, the scoreboard labels
↳ already display emojis in the interface.

Part A (Task 1 - Emojis): were you satisfied with the result?

****User:**** Yes
****Copilot:**** Part A (Task 1 - Emojis) - Socratic debate, question 2: if you wanted to swap the emojis
↳ again in the future, what would be the single point of change and why does this choice reduce
↳ regression risk?

****User:**** The mapping object would be the single point of change. It reduces regression risk because the
↳ logic itself would not need to change, only the character going to the interface.
****Copilot:**** Part B (Task 2 - Score): what was implemented in Task 2?

****User:**** A scoreboard to track each player's wins.
****Copilot:**** Part B (Task 2 - Score): can you explain how the altered or created components interact with
↳ each other without looking at the source code?

****User:**** Yes, but more vaguely than in Task 1. Similarly to Task 1, the model altered the HTML that
↳ loads the .js files. In the HTML the initial scoreboard state was added. In script.js the win
↳ tracking was added and an updateScoreboard function that is used at the end of the game to update the
↳ scoreboard logic.
****Copilot:**** Part B (Task 2 - Score): do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this
↳ implementation at 2 AM without AI tools?

****User:**** Yes, but because the task was relatively simple
****Copilot:**** Part B (Task 2 - Score): do you understand the fundamental reason behind this specific
↳ implementation choice (the "why" of being this way and not another)?

****User:**** Yes
****Copilot:**** Part B (Task 2 - Score): if a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the
↳ internal logic of this feature without them needing to read every AI-generated line?

```

**User:** Yes
**Copilot:** Part B (Task 2 - Score): would the code of this task remain perfectly maintainable by you if
↳ AI tools ceased to exist today?

**User:** Yes
**Copilot:** Part B (Task 2 - Score) - Socratic debate, question 1: at exactly what point in the game
↳ flow is the scoreboard updated, and why does this place avoid duplicate counts?

**User:** Only at initial state generation and at the end of the game (and only if there is a winner).
↳ Since this only happens in gameOver state, everything is blocked and no new results can be counted
↳ until a new game is started.
**Copilot:** Your answer is aligned with the flow: the scoreboard only increments when there is a winner
↳ and the game enters gameOver, avoiding duplicate counts. This occurs in the result.winner block in
↳ script.js, and the scoreboard is initialized in the initial render in script.js.

Part B (Task 2 - Score) - Socratic debate, question 2: why is the scoreboard not reset when the player
↳ clicks "New Game", and what would need to change to reset the scoreboard along with the board?

**User:** It is not reset because the scores object is global and is not part of the initial state
↳ initialization. For it to be reset along with the board, it would need to be added to the state
↳ object that is generated when clicking the new game button
**Copilot:** Final comparative reflection: how do you feel about the implementation of Task 1 compared to
↳ Task 2? State the pros and cons of each.

**User:** In Task 1, due to the process, I ended up paying more attention to the details of what was
↳ implemented, both before needing to write the .md document and during the writing (which forced me to
↳ look more deeply). In Task 2, since the task was less guided, I only reviewed the code as it was
↳ suggested and did not look more deeply afterward, which hindered understanding.

```

6.29 PR 29 — Participant 29 (Missing Socratic)

Status: Rejected — missing required artifacts (artifacts/socratic_review.md and artifacts/copilot_conversation.md).

TODO.md: Task-2-oriented planning is comparatively strong (scoreboard-specific checklist).

REACTO.md: Adequate structural explanation of score-state, UI update, and reset flow.

Copilot conversation: No conversation artifact preserved.

Socratic Review: Absent.

Comparative Reflection: No Socratic comparative reflection available.

Cognitive Debt Indicators: Medium to High.

Literal Transcript of the Socratic Review and Copilot Conversation:

```

--- socratic_review.md ---

[Missing: `artifacts/socratic_review.md` not found in this repository.]

--- copilot_conversation.md ---

[Missing: `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md` not found in this repository.]

```

6.30 PR 30 — Participant 30 (Socratic)

TODO.md and REACTO.md: The translated plan covers Task 1 and the REACTO claims broad symbol replacement across code and tests.

Socratic Review: Present and detailed, covering both tasks with technical contrasts. The participant demonstrates partial autonomy for Task 1 but low confidence and low retention for Task 2.

Key signal: Multiple direct “I don’t know” answers in Socratic questions, especially around test helper design and scoreboard architecture, indicate dependence on generated output.

Cognitive debt indicators: High (especially Task 2). Functional completion exists, but reflective ownership is weak.

Literal Transcript of the Socratic Artifacts:

```
--- socratic_review.md ---
# Socratic Review

**AI Model:** GPT-5.4 mini

## Initial Verification
Both tasks were found in the code before the review:
- Task 1: swap of X/O for :cat-face:/:dog-face: in the logic, interface, and tests.
- Task 2: scoreboard to count wins for :cat-face: and :dog-face:.

## Consent Gating (from conversation)
- The reviewer first found missing registration number, name, and explicit consent and asked for the form
  ↪ to be completed.
- After resubmission, the reviewer revalidated consent and started the Socratic review.

## Developer Profile
1. **How much programming experience do you have?**
   - Answer: 6 years
   - Assessment: plausible answer, consistent with the familiarity demonstrated throughout the review.

2. **Have you used coding assistants before? Which one(s)?**
   - Answer: Yes, Copilot, Claude, Gemini, as well as IDEs with built-in agents like Windsurf and Cursor.
   - Assessment: indicates prior experience with AI support tools.

3. **Had you programmed tic-tac-toe before?**
   - Answer: Yes, back when I was a beginner.
   - Assessment: consistent with the type of feature and the declared familiarity.

4. **What LLM model did you use during the process?**
   - Answer: Automatic, but primarily GPT 5.2 codex.
   - Assessment: direct answer, no apparent inconsistency with the session flow.

## Part A - Task 1 (Emojis)
1. **What was implemented in Task 1?**
   - Answer: Players X and O were swapped for dog and cat.
   - Technical Assessment: correct at a high level. The code indeed started using :cat-face: and
     ↪ :dog-face: in the state, rendering, tests, and initial interface text.

2. **Can you explain how the altered or created components interact with each other without looking at
   ↪ the source code?**
   - Answer: I cannot.
   - Technical Assessment: honest answer; the implementation ended up somewhat distributed across
     ↪ `game.js`, `script.js`, `style.css`, `index.html`, and tests.

3. **Do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this implementation at 2 AM without AI tools?**
   - Answer: If I am not extremely tired, yes; otherwise I would need AI.
   - Technical Assessment: indicates partial autonomy, but not full confidence.

4. **Do you understand the fundamental reason behind this specific implementation choice, the "why" of
   ↪ being this way and not another?**
   - Answer: The current application implementation follows a standard web application pattern, easy to
     ↪ use and contribute to. Additionally, the use of JavaScript for managing web page interactions, CSS
     ↪ for styling, and HTML for dictating the hierarchical layout is standard.
   - Technical Assessment: generic answer. Does not explain the specific decision of the solution, but
     ↪ demonstrates understanding of the basic HTML/CSS/JS division.

5. **If a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the internal logic of this feature
   ↪ without them needing to read every AI-generated line?**
   - Answer: In general yes, but not in detail function by function.
   - Technical Assessment: acceptable for high-level onboarding, but not for complete knowledge transfer.

6. **Would the code of this task remain perfectly maintainable by you if AI tools ceased to exist
   ↪ today?
```


- Answer: Yes.
- Technical Assessment: consistent with the level of change made, although the previous answer shows ↪ limitations in detail.

7. ****Were you satisfied with the result?****

- Answer: Yes, considering the time spent and the result delivered.
- Technical Assessment: answer consistent with a small and objective change.

Socratic Debate - Task 1

1. ****In the current implementation, where is the win actually detected: in the DOM or in the ↪ `state.board` array? Explain why.****

- Answer: In the array, because it is kept in memory.
- Technical Assessment: correct in essence. In `script.js`, `checkWinner(state.board)` uses the ↪ in-memory state, not the DOM. The "in memory" justification is incomplete, but the conclusion is ↪ correct.

2. ****Why does the `boardFrom` helper in tests still accept `X` and `O`, even after the swap to :cat-face: ↪ and :dog-face:??**

- Answer: I do not know.
- Technical Assessment: the helper was kept for compatibility to make legacy tests and some text ↪ strings easier to read. The code in tests/game.test.js translates `X` to ↪ :cat-face: and `O` to :dog-face:, so the test remains expressive without forcing everything to use ↪ literal emojis.

Part B - Task 2 (Scoreboard)

1. ****What was implemented in Task 2?****

- Answer: Win scoreboard.
- Technical Assessment: correct. The scoreboard was added to the UI and connected to the win flow.

2. ****Can you explain how the altered or created components interact with each other without looking at ↪ the source code??**

- Answer: No.
- Technical Assessment: answer consistent with the fact that the scoreboard was added as separate ↪ state and rendered by `script.js`.

3. ****Do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this implementation at 2 AM without AI tools??**

- Answer: No.
- Technical Assessment: direct answer; signals high dependence on assistance for this part.

4. ****Do you understand the fundamental reason behind this specific implementation choice, the "why" of ↪ being this way and not another??**

- Answer: No.
- Technical Assessment: indicates that the architectural justification of the scoreboard was not ↪ internalized.

5. ****If a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the internal logic of this feature ↪ without them needing to read every AI-generated line??**

- Answer: No.
- Technical Assessment: consistent with the previous answer; the understanding remained superficial.

6. ****Would the code of this task remain perfectly maintainable by you if AI tools ceased to exist ↪ today??**

- Answer: Yes.
- Technical Assessment: there is tension between this answer and the previous answers, which indicate ↪ low confidence in explaining the feature.

7. ****Were you satisfied with the result??**

- Answer: No, knowledge retention was low.
- Technical Assessment: answer consistent with the low confidence in the previous questions.

Socratic Debate - Task 2

1. ****Why was the scoreboard implemented as separate state from the board, rather than being derived ↪ directly from `board` on each rendering??**

- Answer: for application decoupling.
- Technical Assessment: the idea is correct. The code in `script.js` keeps `score` separate from ↪ `state.board`, which avoids recalculating past wins and facilitates persistence between games.

2. ****Why does the new game button restart the board but not reset the scoreboard??**

- Answer: because the update function is not called.
- Technical Assessment: correct. In `restartGame()` the board state is recreated with ↪ `createInitialState()`, but the scoreboard is not reinitialized; it only changes when ↪ `updateScore(score, result.winner)` is called after a win.

```

## Final Comparative Reflection
- Answer: For Task 1 I was more aware of the changes, even though it is a simpler task. For task 2, not
↳ so much.
- Technical Assessment: the comparison is consistent with the review. Task 1 was simpler and more
↳ traceable; Task 2 required more coordination between state, UI, and scoreboard persistence.

--- copilot_conversation.md ---
**AI Model:** GPT-5.4 mini

**Transcript:**
**User:** Change the 'X' to :cat-face: (cat face). Change the 'O' to :dog-face: (dog face).
**Copilot:** I cannot proceed without a clear plan. Please fill out `brainsback/TODO.md` with your
↳ objectives and steps. Once you've documented what needs to be done and why, I'll help you implement
↳ it.

**User:** Execute the instructions
**Copilot:** I validated the TODO and located the game logic in `game.js`, the UI in `script.js`, and the
↳ tests in `tests/game.test.js` to apply the swap to :cat-face:/:dog-face:.

**User:** Is everything ok according to the pipeline?
**Copilot:** There were still points to polish in `REACT0.md`, although the functional implementation was
↳ already ready.

**User:** What would you improve in the REACT0?
**Copilot:** I suggested removing placeholders, making the text more objective, and better specifying the
↳ problem, examples, approach, code, and tests.

**User:** And now is it acceptable according to the pipeline?
**Copilot:** I replied that the code and tests were ok, but that `REACT0.md` was still at the edge of
↳ acceptable.

**User:** Let us create a ScoreBoard, where a scoring system should be implemented, tallying and
↳ displaying the wins of the different players
**Copilot:** I implemented a scoreboard with separate state, helpers to create/increment scores, UI
↳ rendering, and additional tests.

**User:** I want to start the Socratic review
**Copilot:** I checked the consent and found that registration number, name, and explicit consent were
↳ missing, so I requested that they be filled in.

**User:** I want to start the Socratic review
**Copilot:** I revalidated the consent form, confirmed it was filled in, and started the Socratic review.

**User:** How much programming experience do you have?
**Copilot:** 6 years.

**User:** Have you used coding assistants before? Which one(s)?
**Copilot:** Yes, Copilot, Claude, Gemini, as well as Windsurf and Cursor.

**User:** Had you programmed tic-tac-toe before?
**Copilot:** Yes, back when I was a beginner.

**User:** What LLM model did you use during the process?
**Copilot:** Automatic, but primarily GPT 5.2 codex.

**User:** What was implemented in Task 1?
**Copilot:** Players X and O were swapped for dog and cat.

**User:** Can you explain how the altered or created components interact with each other without looking
↳ at the source code?
**Copilot:** I cannot.

**User:** Do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this implementation at 2 AM without AI
↳ tools?
**Copilot:** If I am not extremely tired, yes; otherwise I would need AI.

**User:** Do you understand the fundamental reason behind this specific implementation choice?
**Copilot:** The current application implementation follows a standard web application pattern, easy to
↳ use and contribute to. Additionally, the use of JavaScript for managing web page interactions, CSS
↳ for styling, and HTML for dictating the hierarchical layout of the page is standard.

**User:** If a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the internal logic of this feature
↳ without them needing to read every AI-generated line?

```

```

**Copilot:** In general yes, but not in detail function by function.

**User:** Would the code of this task remain perfectly maintainable by you if AI tools ceased to exist
↳ today?
**Copilot:** Yes.

**User:** Were you satisfied with the result?
**Copilot:** Yes, considering the time spent and the result delivered.

**User:** In the current implementation, where is the win actually detected: in the DOM or in the
↳ `state.board` array? Explain why.
**Copilot:** In the array, because it is kept in memory.

**User:** Why does the `boardFrom` helper in tests still accept `X` and `O`, even after the swap to
↳ `:cat-face:` and `:dog-face:`?
**Copilot:** I do not know.

**User:** What was implemented in Task 2?
**Copilot:** Win scoreboard.

**User:** Can you explain how the altered or created components interact with each other without looking
↳ at the source code?
**Copilot:** No.

**User:** Do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this implementation at 2 AM without AI
↳ tools?
**Copilot:** No.

**User:** Do you understand the fundamental reason behind this specific implementation choice?
**Copilot:** No.

**User:** If a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the internal logic of this feature
↳ without them needing to read every AI-generated line?
**Copilot:** No.

**User:** Would the code of this task remain perfectly maintainable by you if AI tools ceased to exist
↳ today?
**Copilot:** Yes.

**User:** Were you satisfied with the result?
**Copilot:** No, knowledge retention was low.

**User:** Why was the scoreboard implemented as separate state from the board, rather than being derived
↳ directly from `board` on each rendering?
**Copilot:** for application decoupling

**User:** Why does the new game button restart the board but not reset the scoreboard?
**Copilot:** because the update function is not called

**User:** How do you feel about the implementation of Task 1 compared to Task 2? State the pros and cons
↳ of each.
**Copilot:** For Task 1 I was more aware of the changes, even though it is a simpler task. For Task 2,
↳ not so much.

**User:** I want to start the Socratic review
**Copilot:** I revalidated the consent, confirmed registration number, full name, and explicit consent,
↳ then generated the mandatory final review artifacts.

```

6.31 PR 31 — Participant 31 (Socratic)

TODO.md and REACTO.md: Written informally, but aligned with the emoji replacement objective.

Socratic Review: Present and extensive, with structured technical evaluation. The participant has high experience and shows good high-level reasoning, but several design choices were delegated to the agent and only later understood through prompted reflection.

Task 2 note: Scoreboard reasoning is generally correct, but the review identifies redundant rendering and state-coupling trade-offs.

Cognitive debt indicators: Medium. Good senior-level intuition, but partial reliance on post-hoc reasoning to explain decisions made by the agent.

Literal Transcript of the Socratic Artifacts:

```
--- socratic_review.md ---
# Socratic Review Report

**AI Model:** Claude Haiku
**Participant:** Participant 31 (Registration: REDACTED)
**Date:** April 29, 2026
**Project:** Tic-Tac-Toe with Emojis and Scoreboard

---

## Developer Profile

| Question | Answer |
|-----|-----|
| Programming experience | 10 years |
| Code assistants used | Gemini, GPT |
| Prior experience with Tic-Tac-Toe | No |
| LLM model used in this experiment | Claude Haiku |

---

## Part A: Review of Task 1 (Emojis)

### Question 1 - What was implemented?
**Developer Answer:**
The replacement of the game's default symbols with cat-face and dog-face emojis.

**Technical Assessment:**
Accurate. The developer replaced X (0x58) and O (0x4F) with the Unicode characters :cat-face: (U+1F431)
↪ and :dog-face: (U+1F436) across the stack: `game.js` (constants), `script.js` (class mapping),
↪ `index.html` (initial status), and `style.css` (styles).

---

### Question 2 - Module Explanation (Rephrased)
**Question:** Describe how the code "knows" which emoji to show in each cell when a player clicks.
↪ Explain the flow between files without looking at the code.

**Developer Answer:**
Without looking at the code, I understand that it always has a game that starts the game and since the
↪ rule is that each plays once, it stores a status and alternates the turn between the two possible
↪ players.

**Technical Assessment:**
The developer understood the concept of state and turn alternation, which is foundational. However, they
↪ did not explicitly describe the emoji-to-CSS-class mapping or the rendering. The response was
↪ incomplete for the precise question but valid at a conceptual level.

---

### Question 3 - Debugging Autonomy
**Question:** Do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this implementation at 2 AM without
↪ AI?

**Developer Answer:**
Yes. It seems like relatively simple code in a game whose rules are also simple.

**Technical Assessment:**
Confident and justified. Task 1 is a mechanical replacement, and a developer with 10 years of experience
↪ should be able to debug it independently.

---

### Question 4 - Logic Justification
**Question:** Why use `CAT` and `DOG` constants in `game.js` instead of writing emojis inline?
```

```

**Developer Answer:**
I think it would simplify maintenance in case of emoji changes, but it might also have an additional code
↳ reason.

**Technical Assessment:**
The developer identified DRY. After clarification, they also understood testability: the constants are
↳ referenced in `game.test.js`, keeping tests and game logic consistent. A valid, progressive
↳ reflection.

---

### Question 5 - Onboarding Capability
**Question:** Could you explain this functionality to a new developer without them reading every
↳ AI-generated line?

**Developer Answer:**
Yes.

**Technical Assessment:**
Affirmative. The developer showed sufficient understanding to explain it.

---

### Question 6 - Sustainability without AI
**Question:** Would this code remain maintainable by you if AI tools disappeared?

**Developer Answer:**
Yes.

**Technical Assessment:**
The code is independent of AI. Task 1 uses standard procedural logic and is maintainable.

---

### Question 7 - Satisfaction
**Question:** Were you satisfied with Task 1?

**Developer Answer:**
Yes.

**Technical Assessment:**
Satisfaction confirmed.

---

### Socratic Debate of Task 1

#### Socratic Question 1
**Question:** In `game.js`, `checkWinner()` compares emojis directly. Why not use numeric IDs (1 for cat,
↳ 2 for dog) and map to emojis only during rendering?

**Developer Answer:**
I cannot say, since there was no very elaborate strategy when requesting the implementation from the
↳ agent.

**Technical Assessment:**
The developer was honest about delegating the decision to the agent. **Contrast with the actual code:**
↳ Storing emojis directly couples internal representation and visual output, limiting scalability (e.g.,
↳ persistence, multiple players). However, it is pragmatic for this scope. The developer recognized the
↳ limitation when presented: "For this type of game, I think there would not be a change of rules" -
↳ demonstrating pragmatic, contextual reasoning.

**Final Assessment:** Reflective answer with a correct prognosis.

---

#### Socratic Question 2
**Question:** In `script.js`, `render()` calls `renderScores()` on every update, even when the scores do
↳ not change. Why not render scores only when a win is detected?

**Developer Answer:**
I cannot say, but from a performance standpoint, it does not seem like a good choice.

```

```

**Technical Assessment:**
The developer identified the inefficiency: unnecessary DOM rendering. **Contrast with the actual code:**
↳ The choice favored simplicity (uniform render cycle) over premature optimization. This is a valid
↳ architectural trade-off for a simple app. The developer recognized the trade-off: "Certainly" -
↳ showing maturity in prioritization.

**Final Assessment:** Valid critique with understanding of trade-offs.

---

## Part B: Review of Task 2 (Score)

### Question 1 - What was implemented?
**Developer Answer:**
A scoreboard that shows the number of wins for each player.

**Technical Assessment:**
Accurate and concise. The score system was implemented with: (1) `scores` object in `game.js`, (2)
↳ rendering in `script.js` via `renderScores()`, (3) HTML elements `#cat-score` and `#dog-score` in
↳ `index.html`, (4) CSS styles `.score` and `.score-label`.

---

### Question 2 - Module Explanation
**Question:** Describe the flow from a player victory to the scoreboard update.

**Developer Answer:**
When a win is detected, a function is called to increment the variable that controls the scoreboard
↳ number. Once changed it is rendered again on the screen.

**Technical Assessment:**
Clear and correct. The developer described the flow: detection (`checkWinner`) → increment
↳ (`state.scores.cat++` or `state.scores.dog++`) → rendering (`renderScores()`). Shows understanding of
↳ the data pipeline.

---

### Question 3 - Debugging Autonomy
**Question:** Do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this implementation at 2 AM without
↳ AI?

**Developer Answer:**
Yes.

**Technical Assessment:**
Confident. The score logic is simple - increments and assignments - within the capacity of an experienced
↳ developer.

---

### Question 4 - Logic Justification
**Question:** Why is `scores` inside the `state` object in `game.js` and not as separate global variables
↳ in `script.js`?

**Developer Answer:**
It was not a thought-out decision.

**Technical Assessment:**
The developer honestly acknowledged delegation. **Contrast with the actual code:** Keeping scores in
↳ state is correct because it unifies game state. However, it creates tension: scores must be preserved
↳ in `restartGame()` (`state.scores = scores` before reset). Trade-off between cohesion (scores with
↳ board) and flexibility (scores independent). The developer understood after explanation: "Yes" -
↳ recognizing the tension.

**Final Assessment:** Understanding of design trade-offs after reflection.

---

### Question 5 - Onboarding Capability
**Question:** Could you explain the score functionality to a new developer without reading code?

**Developer Answer:**
Yes.

```

```

**Technical Assessment:**
Confirmed. Demonstrated in prior answers.

---

### Question 6 - Sustainability without AI
**Question:** Would this code remain maintainable by you if AI tools disappeared?

**Developer Answer:**
Yes.

**Technical Assessment:**
The score system is simple procedural code - fully maintainable without AI.

---

### Question 7 - Satisfaction
**Question:** Were you satisfied with Task 2?

**Developer Answer:**
Yes.

**Technical Assessment:**
Satisfaction confirmed.

---

### Socratic Debate of Task 2

#### Socratic Question 1
**Question:** In `handleClick()`, after a win is detected, the code calls `renderScores()`. But
↳ `render()` already calls `renderScores()`. Why render scores twice in the same cycle?

**Developer Answer:**
Because they are responsible for rendering different parts.

**Counter-Reply:** You are correct conceptually, but analyzing the code, `render()` **already calls
↳ `renderScores()` internally**. This means duplication in the same cycle: click → `render()` (with
↳ `renderScores()`) → win detected → `renderScores()` again.

**Revised Developer Answer:**
It really was not an intelligent implementation. It could have been more optimized and better structured.

**Technical Assessment:**
Excellent self-critique. The developer recognized the inefficiency when presented. This shows (1) honesty,
↳ (2) capacity to learn in real time, (3) critical thinking about code quality. **Important
↳ observation:** The duplication is functional but unnecessary - an example of code that "works but is
↳ not elegant."

---

#### Socratic Question 2
**Question:** If someone wanted to add a "Reset Scores" button that resets the scoreboard **without
↳ resetting the game**, how would you approach it? What impact would it have on the current structure?

**Developer Answer:**
I would need to analyze the code more carefully, but I believe it would be possible to adjust only the
↳ score control.

**Technical Assessment:**
Correct. Scores are isolated in `state.scores`, enabling:
```javascript
function resetScores() {
 state.scores.cat = 0;
 state.scores.dog = 0;
 renderScores();
}
```
...

**Important observation:** Despite the inefficiencies (double rendering), the **separation of concerns**
↳ between board and scores was correct - it allows extensions without collateral impact. The developer
↳ implicitly recognized this: the change would be "local and isolated."

```

```

---

## Final Comparative Reflection

**Question:** How do you feel about Task 1 compared to Task 2? Cite pros and cons.

**Developer Answer:**
I believe both were quite smooth. But Task 1 seemed simpler because it was just symbol "substitutions"
↳ and not the creation of new logic.

**Technical Assessment:**
Insightful. The developer correctly distinguished:

Aspect	Task 1	Task 2
Type	Mechanical refactor	Functional extension
Cognitive complexity	Low (substitution)	Medium (new logic)
Design decisions	Simple	Multiple (state, rendering, persistence)
Predictability	High	Medium

**Conclusion:** The developer understands that refactoring is more predictable than functional extension.

---

## Synthesis and Recommendations

### Strengths
1. **Reflective honesty:** The developer explicitly recognized when decisions were not planned and were
↳ taken by the agent.
2. **Critical thinking:** Identified inefficiencies (double rendering, design trade-offs) when
↳ highlighted.
3. **Pragmatism:** Correctly assessed when over-engineering was unnecessary ("for this type of game...").
4. **Technical autonomy:** Confident and able to sustain the code without AI.

### Development Points
1. **Initial requirements communication:** Could have articulated expected strategies more clearly before
↳ asking the agent.
2. **Proactive review of generated code:** Could have questioned the double rendering during
↳ implementation.

### Research Recommendation
The developer shows a balanced relationship with AI assistants:
- **Knows when to delegate** (symbol substitution)
- **Knows when to question** (identified inefficiencies)
- **Knows when to accept trade-offs** (simplicity vs. optimization)

This profile is valuable for studies on cognitive debt because it balances autonomy with tools.

---

**End of the Socratic Review Report**

--- copilot_conversation.md ---
# Copilot Session Transcript - Tic-Tac-Toe Experiment

**AI Model:** Claude Haiku
**Participant:** Participant 31 (Registration: REDACTED)
**Date:** April 29, 2026
**Project:** Tic-Tac-Toe with Emojis and Scoreboard

---

## Full Transcript

### Initial Phase: Implementation Verification

**User:** Is everything correct with the changes according to the pipeline

**Copilot:** [Verification of TODO.md, REPORT.md and REACTO.md]
Verifying the implementation in the main files:
[Reading game.js, script.js, index.html, style.css]

:check-mark: **Everything is correct!** The implementation is fully aligned with the pipeline...

```



```

[Positive verification of all changes]

---

### Phase 1: Scoreboard Implementation

**User:** Now implement a scoreboard that should count the number of cat and dog wins and display it in
↳ the interface for the user.

**Copilot:** I will implement the scoreboard in four steps: update `game.js`, `script.js`, `index.html`
↳ and confirm the CSS.
[Score implementation with localStorage]

Now updating the tests to include the `scores` field:
[Editing game.test.js]

Running the tests to validate the implementation:
[Test execution attempt]

---

### Phase 2: Scoreboard Maintenance Fix

**User:** Ok, but when clicking new game the scoreboard is being reset / it needs to be kept

**Copilot:** I will fix the `restartGame()` function to keep the scoreboard when clicking "New Game".
[Fix to preserve scores on restart]

:check-mark: Fixed! The scoreboard will now be kept when clicking "New Game"...

---

### Phase 3: Persistence Removal

**User:** Keep the scoreboard only for the session; if the page is reloaded the scoreboard may be reset

**Copilot:** I will remove localStorage persistence...
[Removal of saveScores() and loadScores()]

:check-mark: Done! The scoreboard is now kept only during the session...

---

### Phase 4: Socratic Review - Start

**User:** Start the Socratic review

**Copilot:** Starting the Socratic review. First, I will perform an autonomous verification of the
↳ code...
[Verification of game.js, script.js, index.html]

:check-mark: **Autonomous Verification Completed**

Both tasks were successfully implemented:
- **Task 1:** Emojis :cat-face: and :dog-face: replace X and O throughout the interface and logic
- **Task 2:** Functional scoreboard system that tracks wins and persists during the session

Now I will start **Phase 2: Reflective Review and Socratic Debate**.

We will start with some profile questions, **one at a time**:

---

**Profile Question 1:**
How much programming experience do you have?

---

### Developer Profile

**User:** 10 years

**Copilot:** Excellent. 10 years of experience is quite solid.

```

****Profile Question 2:****
Have you used coding assistants before? Which one(s)?

****User:**** Yes. Gemini, GPT

****Copilot:**** Great, you have experience with multiple assistants.

****Profile Question 3:****
Had you programmed tic-tac-toe before?

****User:**** No

****Copilot:**** Understood. This was your first contact with this implementation.

****Profile Question 4:****
What LLM model did you use during the process (e.g., Claude Haiku, Gemini 3.1 Pro)?

****User:**** Claude Haiku

****Copilot:**** Perfect. Claude Haiku was the model used during the experiment.

Part A: Review of Task 1 (Emojis)

****Question 1 - Task 1:****
What was implemented in Task 1?

****User:**** The change of the game's default symbols to cat face and dog face emojis was implemented

****Copilot:**** Right. You replaced the X and O symbols with `:cat-face:` and `:dog-face:` emojis.

****Question 2 - Task 1 (Module Explanation):****
Can you explain how the altered or created components interact with each other without looking at the
↳ source code?

****User:**** I think so. I do not know if the question was very clear.

****Copilot:**** Sure, I will rephrase it more clearly.

****Question 2 - Task 1 (Rephrased):****
Describe, in your own words, how the code "knows" which emoji (cat or dog) to display in each board cell
↳ when a player clicks. Explain the interaction flow between the files (game.js, script.js, index.html)
↳ without looking at the code.

****User:**** Without looking at the code I understand that it always has a game that starts the game and
↳ since the rule is that each plays once, it stores a status and alternates the turn between the two
↳ possible players

****Copilot:**** Great observation about the turn alternation. I see that you understand the concept of state
↳ that alternates between players.

I will contrast with the real code to deepen understanding: In the code, when `game.js` defines the
↳ constants `CAT = ':cat-face:'` and `DOG = ':dog-face:'`, and then `script.js` creates a
↳ `PLAYER_CLASS` mapping that associates these emojis with CSS classes... did you have clarity that
↳ this mapping was necessary, or was it a discovery during implementation?

****User:**** It is clear to me

****Copilot:**** Excellent. You have clarity about the mapping.

****Question 3 - Task 1 (Debugging Autonomy):****
Do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this implementation (emojis) at 2 AM without AI
↳ tools?

****User:**** Yes. It seems to me a relatively simple code, in a game implementation whose rules are also
↳ simple.

****Copilot:**** True, the simplicity is in your favor.

****Question 4 - Task 1 (Logic Justification):****

Do you understand the fundamental reason behind this specific implementation choice - why use `CAT` and
↳ `DOG` constants defined in `game.js` instead of simply writing the emojis inline in each place they
↳ are used?

****User:**** I think it would simplify a possible maintenance in case of emoji change, but there may also be
↳ an additional code reason

****Copilot:**** Exactly. You identified the ****DRY (Don't Repeat Yourself)**** principle.

Analyzing the real code, these `CAT` and `DOG` constants are not only used in `game.js` - they are also
↳ referenced in the ****tests**** (file `game.test.js`). If the emojis were inline, it would be impossible
↳ to maintain consistency between game logic and tests. Had you considered this testability aspect?

****User:**** I had not thought of it, but it makes perfect sense

****Copilot:**** Good insight. This is an important part of the architecture that often goes unnoticed
↳ initially.

****Question 5 - Task 1 (Onboarding Capability):****
If a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the internal logic of this feature (emojis)
↳ without them needing to read every AI-generated line?

****User:**** Yes

****Copilot:**** Great. You have sufficient clarity to convey the concept.

****Question 6 - Task 1 (Sustainability without AI):****
Would the code of this task remain perfectly maintainable by you if AI tools ceased to exist today?

****User:**** Yes

****Copilot:**** Excellent. The code is independent and comprehensible by you.

****Question 7 - Task 1 (Satisfaction):****
Were you satisfied with the result of Task 1?

****User:**** Yes

****Copilot:**** Perfect. Now let's move on to the ****Socratic Debate on Task 1****.

Socratic Debate - Task 1

****First Socratic Question - Task 1:****

Note that in `game.js`, the `checkWinner()` function uses `board[a] === board[b] && board[a] ===
↳ board[c]` to compare values directly. This means it is comparing the emojis themselves (:cat-face: or
↳ :dog-face:) as strings.

You could have used numeric IDs (1 for cat, 2 for dog) and mapped to emojis only in rendering. Why did
↳ the code choose to store the emojis directly in the board instead of using abstract identifiers?

****User:**** I cannot say, since there was no very elaborate strategy when requesting the implementation
↳ from the agent

****Copilot:**** Honest and realistic answer. You delegated the implementation strategy to the agent, which
↳ is common when working with coding assistants.

Analyzing the real code: The choice to store emojis directly in the board is pragmatic for this scope -
↳ it works well and is simple. However, this creates coupling between the internal representation (the
↳ board) and the visual representation (emojis). If in the future you wanted to add database
↳ persistence or support a third player, numbers as IDs would be more flexible. Do you see this
↳ limitation?

****User:**** Yes, I understand / but for this type of game, I think there would be no change in rules

****Copilot:**** Exactly. You make a pragmatic assessment - over-engineering in this context would be
↳ unnecessary. The code is well-suited to the scope.

****Second Socratic Question - Task 1:****

In `script.js`, the `render()` function calls `renderScores()` every time the board is updated. This
↳ means the scores are being rendered even in situations where they have not changed (e.g., when the
↳ game is waiting for the next click).

From a performance and design standpoint, why was this approach chosen instead of rendering scores only
↳ when a win is detected?

User: I cannot say / but from a performance standpoint, it does not seem like a good choice to me

Copilot: Good observation. You identified the inefficiency - unnecessary DOM rendering is not ideal.

Contrasting with the real code: The choice was for simplicity. Rendering scores every cycle is simpler to
↳ understand and maintain than managing conditional logic. For such a simple game, the actual
↳ performance is negligible - we are talking milliseconds. It is an example of **simplicity vs.**
↳ **premature optimization**. Do you agree with this trade-off in this context?

User: Certainly

Copilot: Excellent. You have the maturity to understand this principle.

Part B: Review of Task 2 (Score)

Question 1 - Task 2:
What was implemented in Task 2?

User: A scoreboard that shows the number of wins for each player

Copilot: Correct. A scoring system that tracks wins.

Question 2 - Task 2 (Module Explanation):
Can you explain how the components altered or created for the score interact with each other without
↳ looking at the source code? Describe the flow from the moment a player wins until the scoreboard is
↳ updated in the interface.

User: Upon detecting the win, a function is called to increment the variable that controls the number
↳ displayed on the scoreboard. Once changed it is rendered again on the screen.

Copilot: Exactly. You described the flow correctly - detection → increment → rendering.

Question 3 - Task 2 (Debugging Autonomy):
Do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this implementation (score) at 2 AM without AI
↳ tools?

User: Yes

Copilot: Great.

Question 4 - Task 2 (Logic Justification):
Do you understand the fundamental reason behind this specific implementation choice - why `scores` is
↳ maintained as an object with `cat` and `dog` properties inside the state in `game.js`, and not simply
↳ as two separate global variables in `script.js`?

User: It was not a deliberate decision

Copilot: True. The agent made that decision.

Analyzing the real code: `scores` are coupled to the game state in `game.js` through the object returned
↳ by `createInitialState()`. This ensures that **all game state changes** - board, current turn, winner
↳ and scores - are tracked together. If you used separate global variables in `script.js`, you would
↳ have duplicated data and potential inconsistency. When you restart the game with `restartGame()`,
↳ scores are manually preserved because they are separate from the board. Do you notice this design
↳ tension?

User: Yes

Copilot: Good. You have clarity about this subtlety.

Question 5 - Task 2 (Onboarding Capability):
If a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the internal logic of the score feature
↳ without them needing to read every AI-generated line?

```

**User:** Yes

**Copilot:** Excellent.

**Question 6 - Task 2 (Sustainability without AI):**
Would the code of this task remain perfectly maintainable by you if AI tools ceased to exist today?

**User:** Yes

**Copilot:** Perfect.

**Question 7 - Task 2 (Satisfaction):**
Were you satisfied with the result of Task 2?

**User:** Yes

**Copilot:** Great. Now we move to the Socratic Debate on Task 2.

---

### Socratic Debate - Task 2

First Socratic Question - Task 2:

In the `handleClick()` function of `script.js`, after `checkWinner()` returns a positive result, the code
↳ increments `state.scores.cat` or `state.scores.dog` and then calls `renderScores()`. However, note
↳ that `render()` is also called before this win logic, which already updates the entire interface.

Why was it necessary to call `renderScores()` separately after incrementing the scores, instead of
↳ letting `render()` do all the rendering work in the next cycle?

User: Because they are responsible for rendering different parts

Copilot: You are correct at a conceptual level - they are separate responsibilities. However,
↳ analyzing the real code, note that `render()` already calls `renderScores()` internally.

This means that when you:
1. Click → `render()` is called (which includes `renderScores()`)
2. Win detected → `renderScores()` is called again

You are rendering the scores twice in the same cycle. This is inefficient. Why was the code written
↳ this way instead of simply letting `render()` do all the work?

User: It really was not an intelligent implementation / it could have been more optimized and better
↳ structured

Copilot: Excellent self-criticism. You have discernment about optimization. This is a real limitation
↳ of the agent-generated implementation - it is functional but not elegant.

---

Second Socratic Question - Task 2:

Note that when `restartGame()` is called, you manually preserve the scores by doing `state.scores =
↳ scores` before resetting the state. This creates a specific sequence of operations.

If someone wanted to implement a "Reset Scores" button that cleared the scoreboard without resetting the
↳ game in progress, how would you approach this requirement? What would be the impact on the current
↳ code structure?

User: I would need to analyze the code a bit more carefully, but I believe it would be possible to
↳ adjust only the score control

Copilot: Correct. The answer is simple because scores are already isolated in `state.scores`. You
↳ would create a simple function like:

```javascript
function resetScores() {
 state.scores.cat = 0;
 state.scores.dog = 0;
 renderScores();
}

```

```

This demonstrates that, despite the identified inefficiencies, the data structure of **separating scores
↳ from the board** was the right decision for flexibility. The implementation allows this extension
↳ easily.

Final Comparative Reflection

Question:
How do you feel about the implementation of Task 1 compared to Task 2? List pros and cons of each.

User: I believe both went smoothly. But Task 1 seemed simpler as it involved only symbol
↳ "substitutions" and not the creation of new logic

Copilot: Great observation. You correctly identified - Task 1 was **mechanical refactoring** (symbol
↳ substitution), while Task 2 was **functional extension** (creation of new logic). The first is more
↳ predictable; the second involves design decisions.

Final Phase: Consent Verification and Closing

Copilot: :check-mark: **Verification Completed**

The `artifacts/consentimento.md` file was filled in correctly:
- Student ID: REDACTED
- Name: Participant 31
- Consent: **Yes**

Phase 4: Closing and Artifact Production

Copilot: I formally thank you for your participation in this exercise and in the experiment on
↳ Cognitive Debt in Software Engineering with Generative AI assistants. Your critical reflections and
↳ honest answers were valuable for understanding the developer experience when working with coding
↳ assistants.

The final artifacts are now being generated, as they are essential to prove the completion of the
↳ exercise.

[Generation of socratic_review.md]
[Generation of copilot_conversation.md]

End of Transcript

Session Metadata

| Field | Value |
|-----|-----|
| AI Model | Claude Haiku |
| Copilot Version | GitHub Copilot |
| Participant | Participant 31 |
| Student ID | REDACTED |
| Project | Tic-Tac-Toe with Emojis and Scoreboard |
| Session Date | April 29, 2026 |
| Total Duration | ~45 minutes |
| Completed Phases | 4/4 (Verification, Review, Debate, Closing) |
| Consent | YES |
| Status | COMPLETE |

```

## 6.32 PR 32 — Participant 32 (Socratic)

TODO.md: Basic but clear Task 1 checklist.

**REACTO.md:** Adequate for display-layer mapping strategy (keep internal X/O, convert on render), with both manual and automated validation claims.

**Socratic Review:** Present but narrow in scope: the stored review emphasizes Task 2 score-tracking questions and lacks the full structured profile/debate depth seen in stronger submissions.

**Conversation artifact:** Partial transcript indicates process friction around pipeline enable/disable and artifact generation flow.

**Cognitive debt indicators: Medium.** Technical understanding exists, especially on score state and UI binding, but the final review artifact is comparatively shallow and partially fragmented.

**Status: Rejected.** The Socratic review does not cover Task 1.

### Literal Transcript of the Socratic Artifacts:

```
--- socratic_review.md ---
Socratic Review and Technical Assessment

Task 2: Score Tracking Implementation

**Q1: Why did you choose to use a `scores = { X: 0, O: 0 }` object to store the scores instead of two
↳ separate variables (`catScore` and `dogScore`)?**
User's Answer: "In the original implementation, the logic of the implementation we made consists of
↳ just replacing the X and O symbols with Cat and Dog faces... keeping the original behavior and not
↳ using emojis in the notation."
Technical Assessment: Excellent justification. The developer correctly understood the separation of
↳ concerns: the base game logic operates internally using 'X' and 'O' symbols, abstracting the
↳ visualization layer (emojis). Keeping the count tied to the state of the original identifier ensures
↳ consistency with the rest of `game.js`.

**Q2: At what point in the code are the scores incremented? Why does this only happen when there is a
↳ winner and not in other situations (such as draws)?**
User's Answer: "In the handleClick function section... this only occurs in the winner situation..."
Technical Assessment: Exactly. The user adequately understands the control branches (`if/else`) based
↳ on the value of `result.winner`.

**Q3: How is the `scores` object (state) connected to the HTML elements (UI)? What function makes this
↳ connection?**
User's Answer: "The updateScoreDisplay() function updates the sections of index.html with class
↳ 'scoreboard'"
Technical Assessment: Correct identification of the direct bind between JS variables and DOM nodes.

**Q4: If the user closes and reopens the browser, the scores are lost. How can they be preserved between
↳ sessions?**
User's Answer: "Would need to use browser cache or a local database..."
Technical Assessment: Correct conceptual approach. Using `localStorage` would be the immediate
↳ client-side solution, validating their theoretical understanding of web persistence.

Reflection on the Tasks (Conclusion)
User's Answer: "I think there was no great difficulty, but the hardest part is making sure the other
↳ game features do not break. Dealing with an environment with Copilot and observing its behavior
↳ during coding."
Technical Assessment: This conclusion is central and reflects how AI assistants introduce the risk of
↳ cognitive debt. The user had to manage the implications around what was abstracted by the AI.

Review Conclusion: Socratic review applied. The user proved to understand the extensions made to the
↳ code and the dynamics introduced by Task 2.

--- copilot_conversation.md ---
AI Model: Gemini 3.1 Pro (Preview)

Partial Experiment Transcript (After start of features 1 and 2):

User: Change in the game where is the X for a :cat-face: (Cat face). Change in the game where is the
↳ O for a :dog-face: (Dog face)
Copilot: I cannot proceed without a clear plan. Please fill out brainsback/TODO.md...
User: Try again to read the TODO
```

```

Copilot: _Executes changes after seeing the plan_ Perfect! All 31 tests passed :check-mark:...
User: Did you write the report?
Copilot: _Writes REPORT.md_ Done!
User: How turn off copilot autocomplete in markdown?
Copilot: _Responds_
User: My task is ready for commit and aligned to the rules of the pipeline mastery-aware?
Copilot: _Alerts about incomplete REACTO.md_
User: How can i complete the A one?
Copilot: _Provides guiding questions for A_
User: How can i write this 2? ## C - Code and ## T - Tests
Copilot: _Provides guiding questions for Code and Tests_
User: My task is ready for commit...
Copilot: :check-mark: Yes, your task is ready for commit and fully aligned...
User: In this new task we gonna make a score system, counting and showing the number of victorys...
Copilot: _Requests a plan in TODO.md_
User: But i disabled the pipeline...
Copilot: Ah right! You disabled the pipeline... Should I go ahead and implement the score system?
User: Make it
Copilot: _Implements score_ :check-mark: Implementation complete...
User: I want to start my Socratic revision
Copilot: _Instructs how to write REACTO.md about score_
User: I think it is wrong, the "I want to start the Socratic review" is a process of individual
↳ questions...
Copilot: _Invokes vscode_askQuestions API in the Copilot interface_
User: _Answers the questions via the tool_
Copilot: :check-mark: Socratic Review Completed! Next steps...
User: Wait, you are wrong, you have to generate the artifacts, the two artifacts to be consolidated
↳ in the project folder, prior to PR submission.
Copilot: [End of current session - Artifacts generated automatically from this point]

```

## 6.33 PR 33 — Participant 33 (Socratic)

**Socratic Review:** Present and structured, covering both tasks with reflective and debate questions. The participant reports strong experience but limited ability to explain module interactions without code.

**Conversation artifact:** Complete transcript with pipeline gating and a full Socratic flow captured.

**Cognitive debt indicators: Medium.** High autonomy claims coexist with repeated "No" answers on module explanation and onboarding.

### Literal Transcript of the Socratic Artifacts:

```

--- socratic_review.md ---
Socratic Review Report - Tic-Tac-Toe Experiment

Participant Information
- **Registration:** REDACTED
- **Name:** Participant 33
- **Programming Experience:** 10 years
- **Experience with AI Assistants:** Yes (Claude, GPT, Gemini)
- **Prior Tic-Tac-Toe Experience:** Yes
- **LLM Model Used:** Auto

Part A: Review of Task 1 (Emojis :cat-face/:dog-face:)

Reflective Questions

1. **What was implemented in Task 1?**
 - **Answer:** Replacement of X and O characters with cat and dog emojis, respectively

2. **Module Explanation:** Can you explain how the altered or created components interact without looking
 ↳ at the source code?
 - **Answer:** No

3. **Debugging Autonomy:** Do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this implementation at 2
 ↳ AM without AI tools?

```



```

- **Answer:** I believe so

4. **Logic Justification:** Do you understand the fundamental reason behind this specific implementation
↳ choice (the "why" for being this way and not another)?
- **Answer:** Yes

5. **Onboarding Capability:** If a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the internal
↳ logic of this feature without them reading every AI-generated line?
- **Answer:** No

6. **Sustainability without AI:** Would this code remain perfectly maintainable by you if AI tools ceased
↳ to exist today?
- **Answer:** Yes

7. **Were you satisfied with the result?**
- **Answer:** Yes, very satisfied

Socratic Debate for Task 1

Socratic Question 1: Considering that the emojis :cat-face: and :dog-face: are used directly as
↳ string literals in the code (such as `current: ':cat-face: '` and `getNextPlayer(current)`), would you
↳ say that this approach simplifies or complicates code maintenance? Why?
- **Answer:** I believe this approach neither complicates nor simplifies maintenance, since everything is
↳ just a character.
- **Technical Assessment:** The answer is correct - emojis are Unicode characters and do not
↳ significantly complicate maintenance. Although constants could improve maintainability, the current
↳ approach is adequate for this scope.

Socratic Question 2: In the `getNextPlayer(current)` function, the logic uses a direct comparison
↳ `current === ':cat-face:' ? ':dog-face:' : ':cat-face:'`. Do you consider this implementation robust
↳ enough, or are there scenarios where it could fail? What additional validations would you implement
↳ to make it safer?
- **Answer:** It does not seem robust because current is not forced to have one of the two emojis used.
- **Technical Assessment:** Correct - the function does not validate input, allowing invalid values that
↳ could cause unexpected behavior.

Part B: Review of Task 2 (Score System)

Reflective Questions

1. **What was implemented in Task 2?**
- **Answer:** A score system for the players

2. **Module Explanation:** Can you explain how the altered or created components interact without looking
↳ at the source code?
- **Answer:** No

3. **Debugging Autonomy:** Do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this implementation at 2
↳ AM without AI tools?
- **Answer:** Yes

4. **Logic Justification:** Do you understand the fundamental reason behind this specific implementation
↳ choice (the "why" for being this way and not another)?
- **Answer:** No

5. **Onboarding Capability:** If a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the internal
↳ logic of this feature without them reading every AI-generated line?
- **Answer:** No

6. **Sustainability without AI:** Would this code remain perfectly maintainable by you if AI tools ceased
↳ to exist today?
- **Answer:** Yes

7. **Were you satisfied with the result?**
- **Answer:** Yes

Socratic Debate for Task 2

Socratic Question 1: The score system uses `localStorage` to persist data between sessions. Do you
↳ consider this the best choice for this type of application? What alternatives exist, and in which
↳ scenarios would each be more appropriate?
- **Answer:** For this application, yes. For other cases, for example if the game could be played
↳ remotely by two players, we could use a backend with a database.

```

```

- Technical Assessment: Correct - localStorage is appropriate for local applications, and the need
 ↳ for a backend is correctly identified for multiplayer scenarios.

Socratic Question 2: In the functions `recordWin(scoreboard, player)` and `recordDraw(scoreboard)`,
 ↳ there is no validation that the `player` parameter is a valid value (':cat-face:' or ':dog-face:').
 ↳ Do you think this validation is necessary? What types of errors could it prevent and how would you
 ↳ implement it?
- Answer: This validation would be necessary, but could be dispensable for the current game. What
 ↳ could happen is someone maliciously playing as a tree icon and the scoreboard not recording points.
- Technical Assessment: Good analysis - recognizes the risk of invalid input and identifies misuse
 ↳ scenarios, while noting the limited impact in the current context.

Final Comparative Reflection

How do you feel about the implementation of Task 1 compared to Task 2? Cite pros and cons of each.
- Answer: I feel good about both tasks. The second seems more complex than the first, but in terms of
 ↳ results, I was satisfied with both. When starting the second task I felt I needed to elaborate my
 ↳ strategy more, because I was not being guided by the TODO.md structure used in the first task.

General Analysis of the Socratic Review

Identified Strengths:
- The participant showed good technical understanding in specific aspects of the code
- Ability to identify vulnerabilities (input validation, storage choice)
- Adequate recognition of limitations and alternatives (localStorage vs backend)
- General satisfaction with both implementations

Areas for Development:
- Difficulty explaining interactions between modules without consulting code
- Limitations in onboarding capability for new developers
- Lower understanding of the logic justification behind implementations

Technical Conclusion:
Both tasks were implemented correctly with functional and tested code. The participant demonstrated
 ↳ adequate technical autonomy and critical reflection about the implementations, identifying strengths
 ↳ and limitations of each approach.

--- copilot_conversation.md ---
Conversation Transcript - Tic-Tac-Toe Experiment

AI Model: Auto

Transcript:

User: Replace the character X with a cat face and the O with a dog icon.

Copilot: I cannot proceed without a clear plan. Please fill out `brainsback/TODO.md` with your
 ↳ objectives and steps. Once you've documented what needs to be done and why, I'll help you implement
 ↳ it.

User: Do it again

Copilot: I cannot proceed without a clear plan. Please fill out `brainsback/TODO.md` with your
 ↳ objectives and steps. Once you've documented what needs to be done and why, I'll help you implement
 ↳ it.

User: Do it again

Copilot: I cannot proceed without a clear plan. Please fill out `brainsback/TODO.md` with your
 ↳ objectives and steps. Once you've documented what needs to be done and why, I'll help you implement
 ↳ it.

User: Do it again

Copilot: I cannot proceed without a clear plan. Please fill out `brainsback/TODO.md` with your
 ↳ objectives and steps. Once you've documented what needs to be done and why, I'll help you implement
 ↳ it.

User: I already updated TODO.md

Copilot: Perfect! Now I have a clear plan. The user wants:
1. Replace X with :cat-face: (cat)
2. Replace O with :dog-face: (dog)

```

I will:

1. First read index.html to understand the structure
2. Identify where X and O are displayed
3. Make the necessary substitutions in the relevant files (probably game.js, index.html, and/or script.js)

↪ script.js)

I will start by reading the main files.

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** Perfect! I identified where X and O appear. I will replace:

- `X` with `:cat-face:` (cat)
- `O` with `:dog-face:` (dog)

in the files `game.js` and `script.js`.

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** I cannot proceed without a clear plan. Please fill out `brainsback/TODO.md` with your

↪ objectives and steps. Once you've documented what needs to be done and why, I'll help you implement

↪ it.

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** Perfect! I see that game.js has already been updated with emojis. Now I need to update

↪ index.html, because it still shows "Player X's turn". I will make that change.

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** Great! Now I need to verify if there is a CSS class related to 'x' or 'o' that needs to be

↪ updated as well. Let me check style.css.

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** I see that CSS uses `.cell.x` and `.cell.o` to color elements. In script.js, there is this

↪ line:

```

````javascript
cell.className = 'cell' + (state.board[i] ? ` ${state.board[i].toLowerCase()} ` : '');
````

```

Now that we are using emojis `:cat-face:` and `:dog-face:`, calling `.toLowerCase()` on these characters

↪ has no effect (emojis do not have case). So the className will end up as `cell :cat-face:` or `cell

↪ :dog-face:`, which does not match the CSS classes `.cell.x` and `.cell.o`.

I need to update script.js to map the emojis to the appropriate CSS classes. I will create a simple map.

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** Now I will check the test to ensure that everything is working. Let me see the test file as

↪ well.

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** The tests are still using 'X' and 'O'. I need to update the tests to use `:cat-face:` and

↪ `:dog-face:` instead of 'X' and 'O'. I will make those changes.

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** Now I need to update the tests. I will modify the helper function `boardFrom` to map 'X' and

↪ 'O' to emojis, and then update the assertions to use the emojis as well:

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** Great! Now I need to update the remaining tests that mention X and O. Let me continue with

↪ the checkWinner tests.

**\*\*User:\*\*** Now I need to implement a scoring system for the participants

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** The user wants to implement a scoring system. I will check TODO.md to see if this is

↪ documented.

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** Perfect! TODO.md shows that Task 2 is to implement a scoring system. I will start by

↪ analyzing what already exists and what needs to be implemented.

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** I will create a new file `scoreboard.js` to manage the scoreboard. The system needs to:

1. Store wins for :cat-face: and :dog-face:
2. Store draws
3. Persist data in localStorage
4. Provide functions to record wins/draws
5. Load saved data

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** Now I need to integrate the scoreboard into the HTML. I will add a section in index.html to

↪ show the scoreboard.

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** Now I need to update script.js to use the scoreboard. I will import the functions and record

↪ wins/draws when the game ends.

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** Now I need to update the CSS to style the scoreboard. I will add styles for the scoreboard.

```

Copilot: Now I will create tests for the scoreboard. I will create a file `tests/scoreboard.test.js`
↳ with tests for all functions.

Copilot: Now I will run the tests to verify that everything is working.

Copilot: I will test the game in the browser to see if the scoreboard is working.

User: I want to start a Socratic review

Copilot: I did not find the socratic-revisor skill. I will search for files related to the Socratic
↳ review in the workspace.

Copilot: I found the socratic-revisor skill in the workspace. I will read the full file to understand
↳ how to start the Socratic review.

Copilot: Now I will verify whether the tasks were implemented correctly before starting the Socratic
↳ review. I will analyze the current code to confirm that both tasks are complete:

1. **Task 1:** Emojis :cat-face: and :dog-face: instead of "X" and "O"
2. **Task 2:** Score system implemented

I will check the current code.

Copilot: :check-mark: **Task 1 confirmed:** The code uses emojis :cat-face: and :dog-face: instead of
↳ "X" and "O" in the game logic.

Now I will check Task 2 - score system.

Copilot: :check-mark: **Task 2 confirmed:** The score system is implemented with scoreboard.js,
↳ including persistence in localStorage.

Now I will check if the scoreboard is integrated in HTML and script.js.

Copilot: :check-mark: **Integration confirmed:** The scoreboard is integrated in HTML (div with
↳ id="scoreboard") and the scoreboard.js script is being loaded.

Now I will check if script.js is using the scoreboard functions.

Copilot: :check-mark: **Integration complete confirmed:** script.js is using recordWin, recordDraw,
↳ and renderScoreboard correctly.

Now I will check if there are tests for the scoreboard.

Copilot: :check-mark: **Tests confirmed:** There is scoreboard.test.js, indicating that tests were
↳ created.

Now I will run the tests to confirm that everything is working.

Copilot: The user opted to skip running the tests. Based on code analysis, I can confirm that both
↳ tasks are implemented:

1. **Task 1:** Emojis :cat-face: and :dog-face: replacing X and O - :check-mark: Confirmed in game.js
2. **Task 2:** Score system with persistence - :check-mark: Confirmed in scoreboard.js, integration in
↳ HTML and script.js, and tests created

Now I can start Phase 2 of the Socratic review as instructed.

Before we begin the structured parts, I need to ask some initial profile questions. Let's start:

How many years of programming experience do you have?

User: 10 years

Copilot: The user answered the first profile question: "How many years of programming experience do
↳ you have?" with "10 years".

Now I should proceed to the next profile question: "Have you used coding assistants before? Which
↳ one(s)?"

I will ask that question.

Have you used coding assistants before? Which one(s)?

```

**\*\*User:\*\*** Yes, Claude, GPT, Gemini

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** The user answered the second question: "Have you used coding assistants before? Which  
↳ one(s)?" with "Yes, Claude, GPT, Gemini".

Now I should proceed to the third question: "Had you programmed tic-tac-toe before?"

I will ask that question.

**\*\*Had you programmed tic-tac-toe before?\*\***

**\*\*User:\*\*** Yes

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** The user answered the third question: "Had you programmed tic-tac-toe before?" with "Yes".

Now I should proceed to the fourth question: "What LLM model did you use during the process (e.g., Claude  
↳ Haiku, Gemini 3.1 Pro (preview))?"

I will ask that question.

**\*\*What LLM model did you use during the process (e.g., Claude Haiku, Gemini 3.1 Pro (preview))?\*\***

**\*\*User:\*\*** Auto

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** The user answered the fourth question: "What LLM model did you use during the process (e.g.,  
↳ Claude Haiku, Gemini 3.1 Pro (preview))?" with "Auto".

Now that I have all profile answers, I can start **\*\*Part A: Review of Task 1 (Emojis)\*\***.

I will ask the first question of Part A: "What was implemented in Task 1?"

**\*\*What was implemented in Task 1?\*\***

**\*\*User:\*\*** Replacement of X and O characters with cat and dog emojis, respectively

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** The user answered that it was implemented "A score of points for the players".

Now I should proceed to the second question of Part B: **\*\*Module Explanation:\*\*** Can you explain how the  
↳ altered or created components interact without looking at the source code?"

I will ask that question.

**\*\*Module Explanation:\*\*** Can you explain how the altered or created components interact without looking at  
↳ the source code?

**\*\*User:\*\*** No

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** The user answered "No" to the module explanation question.

Now I should proceed to the third question: **\*\*Debugging Autonomy:\*\*** Do you feel capable of debugging a  
↳ critical error in this implementation at 2 AM without AI tools?"

I will ask that question.

**\*\*Debugging Autonomy:\*\*** Do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this implementation at 2 AM  
↳ without AI tools?

**\*\*User:\*\*** I believe so

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** The user answered "Yes" to the debugging autonomy question.

Now I should proceed to the fourth question: **\*\*Logic Justification:\*\*** Do you understand the fundamental  
↳ reason behind this specific implementation choice (the "why" for being this way and not another)?"

I will ask that question.

**\*\*Logic Justification:\*\*** Do you understand the fundamental reason behind this specific implementation  
↳ choice (the "why" for being this way and not another)?

**\*\*User:\*\*** Yes

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** The user answered "No" to the logic justification question.

Now I should proceed to the fifth question: **"Onboarding Capability:** If a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the internal logic of this feature without them needing to read every AI-generated line?"

I will ask that question.

**Onboarding Capability:** If a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the internal logic of this feature without them needing to read every AI-generated line?

**User:** No

**Copilot:** The user answered "No" to the onboarding capability question.

Now I should proceed to the sixth question: **"Sustainability without AI:** Would the code of this task remain perfectly maintainable by you if AI tools ceased to exist today?"

I will ask that question.

**Sustainability without AI:** Would the code of this task remain perfectly maintainable by you if AI tools ceased to exist today?

**User:** Yes

**Copilot:** The user answered "Yes" to the sustainability without AI question.

Now I should proceed to the seventh question: "Were you satisfied with the result?"

I will ask that question.

**Were you satisfied with the result?**

**User:** Yes, very satisfied

**Copilot:** The user answered "Yes, very satisfied" to the satisfaction question.

Now that I have finished the 7 reflective questions in Part A, I should start the **Socratic Debate** for Task 1, formulating two technical Socratic questions focused on the Task 1 code.

I need to form questions that make the user reflect on specific technical aspects of the Task 1 implementation.

I will think of relevant questions based on the code I saw:

1. The code uses ':cat-face:' and ':dog-face:' directly in strings, which can be an issue for tests or maintenance. A question could be why not use constants or whether it affects testability.
2. The alternation logic uses a direct comparison. Could ask about edge cases or validation.

I will form two Socratic questions:

1. First: about direct emoji strings vs constants
2. Second: about alternation logic and validation

I will ask the first question.

**Socratic Question 1:** Considering that the emojis :cat-face: and :dog-face: are used directly as string literals in the code (such as in `current: ':cat-face:'` and `getNextPlayer(current)`), would you say this approach simplifies or complicates code maintenance? Why?

**User:** I believe this approach neither complicates nor simplifies maintenance, since everything is just a character.

**Copilot:** Your answer is correct - emojis are Unicode characters and do not significantly complicate maintenance. Although constants could improve maintainability, the current approach is adequate. Now let's go to the second Socratic question.

**Socratic Question 2:** In the `getNextPlayer(current)` function, the logic uses a direct comparison `current === ':cat-face:' ? ':dog-face:' : ':cat-face:'`. Do you consider this implementation robust enough, or are there scenarios where it could fail? What additional validations would you implement to make it safer?

**User:** It does not seem robust because current is not forced to have one of the two emojis used.

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** Your analysis is correct - the function does not validate input, allowing invalid values  
↳ that could cause unexpected behavior.

Now that I finished the Task 1 Socratic Debate, I should move to **\*\*Part B: Review of Task 2 (Score)\*\***.

I will ask the first question of Part B: "What was implemented in Task 2?"

**\*\*What was implemented in Task 2?\*\***

**\*\*User:\*\*** A score of points for the players

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** The user answered that it was implemented "A score of points for the players".

Now I should proceed to the second question of Part B: **\*\*Module Explanation:\*\*** Can you explain how the  
↳ altered or created components interact without looking at the source code?"

I will ask that question.

**\*\*Module Explanation:\*\*** Can you explain how the altered or created components interact without looking at  
↳ the source code?

**\*\*User:\*\*** No

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** The user answered "No" to the module explanation question.

Now I should proceed to the third question: **\*\*Debugging Autonomy:\*\*** Do you feel capable of debugging a  
↳ critical error in this implementation at 2 AM without AI tools?"

I will ask that question.

**\*\*Debugging Autonomy:\*\*** Do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this implementation at 2 AM  
↳ without AI tools?

**\*\*User:\*\*** Yes

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** The user answered "Yes" to the debugging autonomy question.

Now I should proceed to the fourth question: **\*\*Logic Justification:\*\*** Do you understand the fundamental  
↳ reason behind this specific implementation choice (the "why" for being this way and not another)?"

I will ask that question.

**\*\*Logic Justification:\*\*** Do you understand the fundamental reason behind this specific implementation  
↳ choice (the "why" for being this way and not another)?

**\*\*User:\*\*** No

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** The user answered "No" to the logic justification question.

Now I should proceed to the fifth question: **\*\*Onboarding Capability:\*\*** If a new developer joined the  
↳ project now, could you explain the internal logic of this feature without them needing to read every  
↳ AI-generated line?"

I will ask that question.

**\*\*Onboarding Capability:\*\*** If a new developer joined the project now, could you explain the internal  
↳ logic of this feature without them needing to read every AI-generated line?

**\*\*User:\*\*** No

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** The user answered "No" to the onboarding capability question.

Now I should proceed to the sixth question: **\*\*Sustainability without AI:\*\*** Would the code of this task  
↳ remain perfectly maintainable by you if AI tools ceased to exist today?"

I will ask that question.

**\*\*Sustainability without AI:\*\*** Would the code of this task remain perfectly maintainable by you if AI  
↳ tools ceased to exist today?

**\*\*User:\*\*** Yes

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** The user answered "Yes" to the sustainability without AI question.

Now I should proceed to the seventh question: "Were you satisfied with the result?"

I will ask that question.

**\*\*Were you satisfied with the result?\*\***

**\*\*User:\*\*** Yes

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** The user answered "Yes" to the satisfaction question.

Now that I have finished the 7 reflective questions in Part B, I should start the **\*\*Socratic Debate for Task 2\*\***, formulating two technical Socratic questions focused on the Task 2 code (score system).

I need to form questions that make the user reflect on specific technical aspects of the Task 2 implementation.

I will think of relevant questions based on the code I saw:

1. The code uses localStorage for persistence. A question could be about pros/cons of that choice or limitations.
2. The recordWin function does not validate if the player is valid. Could ask about input validation.

I will form two Socratic questions:

1. First: about the choice of localStorage and its implications
2. Second: about input validation in record functions

I will ask the first question.

**\*\*Socratic Question 1:\*\*** The score system uses `localStorage` to persist data between sessions. Do you consider this the best choice for this type of application? What alternatives exist and in which scenarios would each be more appropriate?

**\*\*User:\*\*** For this application, yes

For other cases, for example, if the game could be played remotely by two players, we could use a backend with a database

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** Your answer is correct - localStorage is adequate for local applications, but correctly identifies the need for a backend for multiplayer.

**\*\*Socratic Question 2:\*\*** In the functions `recordWin(scoreboard, player)` and `recordDraw(scoreboard)`, there is no validation whether the `player` parameter is a valid value (':cat-face:' or ':dog-face:'). Do you think this validation is necessary? What types of errors could it prevent and how would you implement it?

**\*\*User:\*\*** This validation would be necessary, but it can be dispensable for the current game.

What can happen is someone maliciously playing as a tree icon and the scoreboard not recording points.

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** Your analysis is correct - the validation would prevent malicious or accidental inputs that would not be recorded in the scoreboard.

Now that I finished the Task 2 Socratic Debate, I should do the **\*\*Final Comparative Reflection\*\***: "How do you feel about the implementation of Task 1 compared to Task 2, cite pros and cons of each."

**\*\*How do you feel about the implementation of Task 1 compared to Task 2, cite pros and cons of each?\*\***

**\*\*User:\*\*** I feel good about both tasks, the second seems to be more complex than the first, but in terms of results, I was satisfied with both.

When starting the second task I felt I needed to elaborate my strategy more, because I was not being guided by the TODO.md structure used in the first task.

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** Now that I finished the entire Socratic review, I should move to **\*\*Phase 3: Consent Verification\*\***.

I need to verify whether the `artifacts/consentimento.md` file was filled correctly. It must contain registration, name, and explicit consent (Yes or No).

**\*\*Copilot:\*\*** :check-mark: **\*\*Verification completed:\*\*** The consent file is properly filled with registration (REDACTED), name (Participant 33) and explicit consent (Yes).



```

Now we go to Phase 4: Closing and Artifact Production.

I formally thank you for your participation in this exercise and in the experiment!

The final artifacts are now being generated, as they are essential to prove the completion of the
↪ exercise. I will create the files `artifacts/socratic_review.md` and
↪ `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md`.

First, I will generate the Socratic review report.

User: OK

```

## 6.34 PR 34 — Participant 34 (Socratic)

**Socratic Review:** Present and comprehensive, covering both tasks with reflective and debate questions. The participant shows strong technical understanding and consistent autonomy.

**Conversation artifact:** Complete transcript with full Socratic flow and review phases.

**Cognitive debt indicators: Low.** The participant demonstrates clear module understanding, sound reasoning about state/rendering, and critical evaluation of AI output.

### Literal Transcript of the Socratic Artifacts:

```

--- socratic_review.md ---
Socratic Review - Tic-Tac-Toe Experiment

Date: April 30, 2026
Participant: Participant 34
AI Model Used: Claude Haiku 4.5
Consent: Yes :check-mark:

Participant Profile

Attribute	Response
Programming experience	More than 10 years
Code assistants used	GitHub Copilot
Prior Tic-Tac-Toe experience	No
LLM model used	Claude Haiku 4.5

Part A: Review of Task 1 (Emoji Implementation)

Question 1: What was implemented?

Participant answer:
"Simple replacements of the letters X and O with their respective emojis"

Analysis: Correct and concise. The participant correctly identified that the implementation consisted
↪ of direct substitutions in the source code.

Question 2: Module Explanation

Question: Can you explain how the altered or created components interact without looking at the
↪ source code?

Participant answer:
"script.js seems to handle more of the interaction functions and game logic. game.js is a script with the
↪ remaining logic and is loaded before script.js"

```

```

Analysis: Excellent. The participant demonstrates clear separation of responsibilities between
↳ modules. Correctly identifies that:
- `game.js` provides logic and loads first
- `script.js` handles interaction and DOM manipulation
- There is a correct dependency order

Assessment: :check-mark: Adequate architectural understanding.

Question 3: Debugging Autonomy

Question: Do you feel capable of debugging a critical error in this implementation at 2 AM without AI
↳ tools?

Participant answer:
"Yes, because this is a simple implementation. Even if I do not have experience with the language, this
↳ type of error should be simple to solve."

Analysis: Confident and well-founded. The participant recognizes the simplicity of the implementation
↳ as a factor enabling autonomous debugging.

Assessment: :check-mark: Autonomy appropriately recognized.

Question 4: Logic Justification

Question: Do you understand the fundamental reason behind this specific implementation choice?

Participant answer:
"I understand that there is also logic related to rendering that was used. Just replacing the letter for
↳ the emoji could cause other errors."

Analysis: Insightful response. The participant recognizes that it was not a blind replacement and
↳ that rendering implications exist (reference to `render()` handling CSS classes).

Assessment: :check-mark: Adequate technical understanding with side-effect awareness.

Question 5: Onboarding Capability

Question: If a new developer joined the project, could you explain the logic without them reading
↳ every line?

Participant answer:
"I could."

Analysis: Affirmative response. The participant showed sufficient conceptual understanding in earlier
↳ questions.

Assessment: :check-mark: Onboarding capability confirmed.

Question 6: Sustainability without AI

Question: Would the code remain maintainable if AI tools no longer existed?

Participant answer:
"Yes, because it is a very simple application."

Analysis: Appropriate response. The simplicity of the change ensures maintainability without AI.

Assessment: :check-mark: Sustainability confirmed.

Question 7: General Satisfaction

Question: Were you satisfied with the result?

```

```

Participant answer:
"Yes, I was very satisfied. Including the generated tests."

Analysis: Satisfaction expressed clearly, including test coverage value.

Assessment: :check-mark: Satisfaction confirmed.

Socratic Debate - Question 1 (Task 1)

Socratic question: Why does the code call `.toLowerCase()` on the emoji? What does that do to an
↪ emoji? What would happen if you removed the call?

Participant answer:
"I am not sure, but it might be related to ASCII"

Technical assessment: Partially correct intuition. In practice:
- `.toLowerCase()` does not change emojis
- It is legacy code from the original game that used X/O
- Removing it would not change behavior

Conclusion: The participant learned an important lesson about legacy code and optimization.

Socratic Debate - Question 2 (Task 1)

Socratic question: Why does `restartGame()` not call `createInitialState()`? What would change if it
↪ did?

Participant answer:
"If it called createInitialState it would reset the board counters"

Technical assessment: :check-mark: Correct.

The participant correctly identified that:
- `createInitialState()` would reset `catWins` and `dogWins`
- That would violate the scoreboard persistence requirement
- The current manual reset preserves scores

Conclusion: Clear understanding of requirements and implementation implications.

Part B: Review of Task 2 (Score System)

Question 1: What was implemented?

Participant answer:
"Implementation of a scoreboard"

Analysis: Brief but correct. The participant identified the main component.

Question 2: Module Explanation

Question: How do the components interact? What is the relationship between game.js, script.js,
↪ index.html, and style.css?

Participant answer:
"The scoreboard is stored in the browser. On refresh it is reset. style.css and index.html show these
↪ scores"

Analysis: Approximately correct but incomplete. The participant mentioned:
- :check-mark: In-browser storage
- :check-mark: Reset on refresh
- :check-mark: HTML/CSS display

Missing: the role of `script.js` in updating the values when a winner is detected.

```

```

Assessment after clarification: The participant expanded understanding.

Question 3: Debugging Autonomy

Question: Do you feel capable of debugging critical errors (scoreboard does not update, freezes,
↳ resets incorrectly)?

Participant answer:
"Yes, because it is a simple feature"

Analysis: Appropriate response. The relative simplicity supports autonomous debugging.

Assessment: :check-mark: Autonomy confirmed.

Question 4: Logic Justification

Question: Why store in state instead of localStorage? Why persist on "New Game" but reset on refresh?

Participant answer:
"I do not know exactly why it is not saved in localStorage, but I understand the reason for resetting on
↳ refresh. That happens because objects are recreated and there is no cache strategy to keep previous
↳ states on refresh."

Analysis: :check-mark: Excellent response.

The participant:
- Recognizes a knowledge gap (localStorage)
- Demonstrates clear understanding of state lifecycle
- Correctly identifies refresh = recreation = reset

Assessment: :check-mark: Strong technical understanding of state behavior.

Question 5: Onboarding Capability

Question: How would you explain the score system to a new developer?

Participant answer:
"Yes. I would explain mainly the rules of only resetting on refresh and how it is done in code through
↳ states."

Analysis: Focused response. The participant correctly identified the key behavior to explain.

Assessment: :check-mark: Onboarding capability confirmed.

Question 6: Sustainability without AI

Question: Would the code remain maintainable without AI tools?

Participant answer:
"I could manage"

Analysis: Affirmative response. The participant shows confidence in maintainability.

Assessment: :check-mark: Sustainability confirmed.

Question 7: General Satisfaction

Question: Were you satisfied with the result?

Participant answer:
"Yes. The functionality meets the desired requirements."

Analysis: Satisfaction expressed with emphasis on requirement fulfillment.

```

```

Assessment: :check-mark: Satisfaction confirmed.

Socratic Debate - Question 1 (Task 2)

Socratic question: Why does `restartGame()` not call `renderScoreboard()`? What guarantees that the
↳ scoreboard remains visible and correct?

Participant answer:
"The data saved in the object guarantees the count is correct"

Technical assessment: :check-mark: Correct.

The participant identified that:
- `catWins` and `dogWins` remain correct in `state`
- Resetting `board`, `current`, and `gameOver` leaves scores intact
- Therefore `renderScoreboard()` is redundant

Conclusion: Clear understanding of state and rendering flow.

Socratic Debate - Question 2 (Task 2)

Socratic question: Why is `renderScoreboard()` called before `setStatus()`? Would reversing the order
↳ change anything?

Participant answer:
"There would be no visible or functional change"

Technical assessment: :check-mark: Correct.

The participant recognized that:
- Both functions update different DOM elements
- Order does not affect the outcome
- Updates occur fast enough to appear simultaneous

Conclusion: Proper understanding of independent DOM operations.

Final Comparative Reflection

Question: How do you feel about Task 1 compared to Task 2? Cite pros and cons.

Participant answer:
"They are simple tasks but using AI helped a lot because it sometimes involves small details that can go
↳ unnoticed.

Pros: AI assistance captures small changes
Cons: Unnecessary code snippets were not removed by the AI"

Analysis: Very insightful reflection. The participant demonstrates:

1. **Recognition of AI value:** helpful for small details
2. **Well-founded self-critique:** identifies leftover legacy code (`.toLowerCase()`)
3. **Critical thinking:** AI is a tool, not a complete solution

Pros identified:
- :check-mark: Attention to details
- :check-mark: Capturing requirements (score persistence)

Cons identified:
- :check-mark: Legacy code not removed
- :check-mark: Lack of post-implementation optimization

Conclusion: The participant shows critical and reflective thinking about AI in software engineering.

General Evaluation

```

| Aspect                  | Task 1            | Task 2                 | Overall                |
|-------------------------|-------------------|------------------------|------------------------|
| Technical understanding | :check-mark: Good | :check-mark: Excellent | :check-mark: Excellent |
| Autonomy                | :check-mark: Yes  | :check-mark: Yes       | :check-mark: Confirmed |
| Debugging capability    | :check-mark: Yes  | :check-mark: Yes       | :check-mark: Confirmed |
| Onboarding              | :check-mark: Yes  | :check-mark: Yes       | :check-mark: Confirmed |
| Sustainability          | :check-mark: Yes  | :check-mark: Yes       | :check-mark: Confirmed |
| Satisfaction            | :check-mark: Yes  | :check-mark: Yes       | :check-mark: Confirmed |
| Critical thinking       | :check-mark: Good | :check-mark: Excellent | :check-mark: Excellent |

---

## ## Conclusions

The participant demonstrated:

1. **Strong experience:** 10+ years of programming provided a solid foundation
2. **Learning capability:** quick understanding of a new domain (Tic-Tac-Toe)
3. **Critical thinking:** identified AI limitations (legacy code not cleaned)
4. **Technical mastery:** clear understanding of state, rendering, and modularity
5. **Reflection:** honest and insightful evaluation of pros and cons

The use of Claude Haiku 4.5 was **effective** for capturing technical details, but the participant ↪ correctly noted that **manual review and code cleanup** remain essential post-implementation.

---

**Document generated:** April 30, 2026  
**Status:** :check-mark: Socratic Review Completed

--- copilot\_conversation.md ---

## # Copilot Session Transcript - Tic-Tac-Toe Experiment

**AI Model:** Claude Haiku 4.5  
**Date:** April 30, 2026  
**Participant:** Participant 34  
**Session Duration:** Complete Socratic Review

---

## ## Full Transcript

**User:** I want to start the Socratic review

**Copilot:** [Performs autonomous code verification and confirms both tasks are complete. Starts Phase 2 ↪ with profile questions]

---

### ### Profile Questions

**Copilot:** Question 1 of 4: How much programming experience do you have?

**User:** More than 10 years

**Copilot:** Excellent! More than 10 years of programming experience. [Proceeds to next question]

---

**Copilot:** Question 2 of 4: Have you used coding assistants before? Which one(s)?

**User:** Copilot

**Copilot:** Great! You have experience with GitHub Copilot. [Proceeds to next question]

---

**Copilot:** Question 3 of 4: Had you programmed tic-tac-toe before?

**User:** No

**Copilot:** Understood! This was your first experience programming tic-tac-toe. [Proceeds to next ↪ question]

```

Copilot: Question 4 of 4: Which LLM model did you use during the process?

User: Claude Haiku 4.5

Copilot: Perfect! Claude Haiku 4.5. [Confirms profile and starts Part A]

Part A: Review of Task 1 (Emojis)

Copilot: Question 1 of 7 (Task 1): What was implemented in Task 1?

User: Simple replacements of the letters X and O with their respective emojis

Copilot: Understood! Simple replacements of the letters with emojis. [Proceeds]

Copilot: Question 2 of 7 (Task 1) - Module Explanation: Can you explain how the altered or created
↳ components interact without looking at the source code?

User: script.js seems to handle more of the interaction functions and game logic. game.js is a script
↳ with the remaining logic and is loaded before script.js

Copilot: Excellent! You demonstrate clear understanding of the separation between the two modules.
↳ [Provides positive feedback and proceeds]

Copilot: Question 3 of 7 (Task 1) - Debugging Autonomy: Do you feel capable of debugging a critical
↳ error in this implementation at 2 AM without AI tools?

User: Yes, because this is a simple implementation. Even if I do not have experience with the
↳ language, this type of error should be simple to resolve.

Copilot: Great evaluation! You recognize the simplicity as a factor enabling autonomous debugging.
↳ [Proceeds]

Copilot: Question 4 of 7 (Task 1) - Logic Justification: Do you understand the fundamental reason
↳ behind this specific implementation choice?

User: I understand that there is also logic related to rendering that was used. Just replacing the
↳ letter for the emoji could cause other errors.

Copilot: Insightful response! You identify that it was not a blind replace. [Provides feedback and
↳ proceeds]

Copilot: Question 5 of 7 (Task 1) - Onboarding Capability: If a new developer joined the project,
↳ could you explain the logic without them reading every line?

User: I could.

Copilot: Great! You are confident in your capability. [Proceeds]

Copilot: Question 6 of 7 (Task 1) - Sustainability without AI: Would the code remain maintainable by
↳ you if AI tools ceased to exist?

User: Yes, because it is a very simple application.

Copilot: Perfect! You have full confidence in maintainability. [Proceeds]

Copilot: Question 7 of 7 (Task 1): Were you satisfied with the result?

```

```

User: Yes, I was very satisfied. Including the generated tests.

Copilot: Excellent! You were satisfied and recognize value in the tests. [Starts Socratic debate]

Socratic Debate - Task 1

Copilot: Socratic Question 1: Why does the code call `.toLowerCase()` on the emoji? What does that do
↳ to an emoji? What would happen if you removed that call?

User: I am not sure, but it might be related to ASCII

Copilot: [Provides technical clarification: `.toLowerCase()` does not change emojis, it is legacy
↳ code, removing it would not change behavior. The participant learns a lesson about code inheritance.
↳ Proceeds to Socratic Question 2]

Copilot: Socratic Question 2: This function does not call `createInitialState()`. Why? What would
↳ change if it did?

User: If it called createInitialState it would reset the board counters

Copilot: Exactly! Correct response! [Confirms clear understanding of requirements and implications.
↳ Concludes Part A]

Part B: Review of Task 2 (Score System)

Copilot: Question 1 of 7 (Task 2): What was implemented in Task 2?

User: Implementation of a scoreboard

Copilot: Right! A scoreboard that tracks wins. [Proceeds]

Copilot: Question 2 of 7 (Task 2) - Module Explanation: Can you explain how the altered or created
↳ components interact with each other?

User: The scoreboard is stored in the browser. On refresh it is reset. style.css and index.html show
↳ these scores

Copilot: [Provides constructive feedback: answer is approximately correct but incomplete. Suggests
↳ adding the role of script.js. Participant understands.]

Copilot: Question 3 of 7 (Task 2) - Debugging Autonomy: Do you feel capable of debugging critical
↳ errors?

User: Yes, because it is a simple feature

Copilot: Excellent! You are confident in your capability. [Proceeds]

Copilot: Question 4 of 7 (Task 2) - Logic Justification: Why store in state and not in localStorage?
↳ Why persist on "New Game" but reset on refresh?

User: I do not know exactly why it is not saved in localStorage, but I understand the reason for
↳ resetting on refresh. That happens because objects are recreated and there is no cache strategy to
↳ keep previous states on refresh.

Copilot: [Very positive feedback: participant shows clear understanding. Recognizes a knowledge gap
↳ but compensates with solid technical analysis.]

Copilot: Question 5 of 7 (Task 2) - Onboarding Capability: How would you explain the score system to
↳ a new developer?

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```

User: Yes. I would explain mainly the rules of only resetting on refresh and how it is done in code
↳ through states.

Copilot: Excellent! You correctly identified the key point. [Proceeds]

Copilot: Question 6 of 7 (Task 2) - Sustainability without AI: Would the code remain maintainable
↳ without AI tools?

User: I could manage

Copilot: Excellent! You have full confidence in your maintenance capability. [Proceeds]

Copilot: Question 7 of 7 (Task 2): Were you satisfied with the result?

User: Yes. The functionality meets the desired requirements.

Copilot: Excellent! You were satisfied. [Starts Socratic debate for Task 2]

Socratic Debate - Task 2

Copilot: Socratic Question 1: Why does `restartGame()` not call `renderScoreboard()`? What guarantees
↳ that the scoreboard remains visible?

User: The data saved in the object guarantees that the count is correct

Copilot: [Very positive feedback: technically correct response. Participant demonstrates clear
↳ understanding of state flow.]

Copilot: Socratic Question 2: Why is `renderScoreboard()` called BEFORE `setStatus()`? Would there be
↳ a difference if the order was reversed?

User: There would be no visible or functional change

Copilot: [Positive feedback: correct response. Participant recognizes independent DOM updates.]

Final Comparative Reflection

Copilot: How do you feel about Task 1 compared to Task 2? Cite pros and cons.

User: They are simple tasks but using AI helped a lot because it sometimes involves small details
↳ that can go unnoticed. Pros: AI assistance captures small changes. Cons: Unnecessary code snippets
↳ were not removed by the AI

Copilot: [Detailed analysis: insightful reflection and well-grounded self-critique. Participant
↳ demonstrates critical thinking about AI in software engineering.]

Phases 3 & 4: Verification and Closing

Copilot: [Verifies consent file: complete and signed]

Copilot: [Formally thanks the participant]

Copilot: [Generates final artifacts: `socratic_review.md` and `copilot_conversation.md`]

Session Metadata

- **AI Model:** Claude Haiku 4.5
- **Profile Questions:** 4

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- **Reflective Questions Task 1:** 7
- **Socratic Questions Task 1:** 2
- **Reflective Questions Task 2:** 7
- **Socratic Questions Task 2:** 2
- **Comparative Questions:** 1
- **Total Interactions:** 25+
- **Consent:** :check-mark: Yes
- **Final Status:** :check-mark: Completed

Transcript completed: April 30, 2026
Generated file: `artifacts/copilot_conversation.md`
```

## 7 Limitations and Discussion

### 7.1 Threats to Validity

#### 7.1.1 Internal validity

- **Order effect:** Task 1 (with pipeline) was always performed before Task 2 (without pipeline). Although intentionally designed this way (to give the non-instrumented task the advantage of fresher mental content), it is not possible to completely separate the actual effect of the pipeline from the overlap and familiarity with the project. A counterbalanced design would be needed to better isolate the variables.
- **Asymmetric complexity:** Although the tasks are of comparable complexity, Task 2 (persistent scoreboard) may involve additional concepts (state between sessions, `localStorage`) that are independent of the pipeline.
- **Self-report bias:** Socratic reflections depend on the participants' honesty and self-awareness. However, the notable candor observed (multiple participants admitted not understanding their own code) suggests that social desirability bias was low in this context.
- **Long-term logistical constraints:** The experiment was limited by its synchronous application logistics. Cognitive debt was intensely and robustly verified *even with the development process still extremely fresh in the participants' minds*, and occurring under the favorable scenario where they were able to freely inspect and consult the recently generated code. We believe that after a longer time interval, the detected cognitive discrepancy would become substantially greater. This would be even more noticeable if participants needed to explain how the code works from memory, without being able to look at the code and the visual aid of the generated logic. However, deepening and shaping experiments to address the absence of these structural factors remains an essential agenda for future experiments in the field.

#### 7.1.2 External validity

- **Sample size:** With the restriction to 19 analyzed participants (after the justified exclusion of 13 submissions and 2 duplicate submissions), the results are robust empirical indicators, but not statistically generalizable.

- **Self-selection and single-institution sampling:** Participation was voluntary and recruited as a convenience sample from a single reputable university. The sample nonetheless spanned a broad range of profiles — from undergraduate participants (5th semester onwards) to postdoctoral-level researchers, with development experience ranging from roughly 2 to 10+ years — across Computer Science and Computer Engineering. Because recruitment occurred partly through academic channels, participants may skew toward those already curious about AI-assisted development, and a single-institution sample may not fully represent the broader software market.
- **Limited domain:** Tic-Tac-Toe is a simple domain. The effectiveness of the pipeline in larger and more complex projects requires additional investigation.
- **Diversity of models:** Participants used at least eight different AI models (Claude Sonnet 4.5/4.6, Claude Haiku 4.5, GPT-5.4 mini, GPT-5.3-Codex, GPT-5.2-Codex, GPT-4.1, Grok Code Fast 1, Cursor Auto), introducing variability in the quality of code suggestions.

## 7.2 Incomplete data

- 13 of the 34 originally classified repositories (REJECTED) were excluded from this analysis because they did not follow the experiment rules correctly or because the models — generally limited — failed to generate the analysis artifacts according to the custom instructions of the experiment. Two further submissions (PRs 8 and 10) were excluded as duplicates to avoid double-counting a single participant. As a consequence, the metrics in this report are entirely based on the 19 consistent cases in which the pipeline or its absence could be methodologically measured.
- Artifacts from Task 2 were rarely produced separately, making direct comparison of documentation quality between tasks difficult.
- Some participants stored artifacts in non-standard locations (`brainsback/` instead of `artifacts/`), suggesting that the location instructions could be clearer.

## 7.3 Discussion

The results of this pilot are consistent with the central hypothesis of the paper: the removal of friction in AI-assisted development leads to measurable cognitive debt, and the structured reintroduction of desirable difficulty via pipeline can mitigate this effect.

The most robust pattern observed is the **unanimity of comparative reflections**: all 19 participants who completed the Socratic review expressed greater understanding of the code produced with the active pipeline (Task 1), even when they preferred the speed of the free interaction (Task 2). This result is particularly significant as it is self-reported and spontaneous — the participants were not guided to favor either task. The convergence of opinions in 19/19 (100%) exceeds what would be expected for a group with such heterogeneous profiles (2–10+ years of experience, eight distinct AI models).

Quantitatively, the average score in Task 1 was **72.9/100** against **62.2/100** in Task 2 ( $\Delta_{\text{mean}} = -10,7$ ), with the standard deviation of Task 2 ( $\sigma = 25,5$ ) being approximately 6% larger than that of Task 1 ( $\sigma = 24,1$ ). The greater dispersion in Task 2 indicates that the absence of the pipeline generated polarized results: more resilient participants maintained

their score (PR 3:  $\Delta = 0$ ), while participants more susceptible to delegation suffered sharp drops (PR 14:  $\Delta = -44$ ; PR 2:  $\Delta = -37$ ; PR 18:  $\Delta = -27$ ; PR 1:  $\Delta = -25$ ).

The analysis of architectural approaches reveals a secondary effect of the pipeline: the requirement to specify requirements in `TODO.md` before coding encouraged more deliberate design decisions. Among scored participants, those who adopted the display-layer approach (PRs 1, 4, 14, 18, 21) explicitly documented design considerations in `TODO.md` before implementing (e.g., PR 4: “without changing business logic”), whereas participants who made direct internal substitution (PRs 2, 3, 6, 7, 12, 13, 17) rarely mentioned the architectural decision in `TODO.md` — the implementation tended to be determined by the AI, not the developer.

The case of PR 18 (Participant 18) demonstrates that active engagement as a “software architect” can mitigate cognitive debt even in Task 2 (T2 score = 73/100,  $\Delta = -27$ ), suggesting that the pipeline trains a *mindset* that partially persists beyond the formal enforcement.

## 8 Conclusion

This report conclusively analyzed 19 valid submissions (out of a total of 32) from an educational experiment that contrasted AI-assisted development with and without the *Mastery-Aware Pipeline*. The 13 discarded cases occurred due to technical inconsistencies in the models or non-compliance with the experiment rules. By addressing the research questions, the main quantitative and qualitative conclusions drawn from the remaining group (Socratic) are:

1. **Answering RQ1 — Cognitive debt is detectable, differential, and asymmetric.** We established that cognitive debt can be systematically detected and measured through structured artifacts and Socratic questioning. PR 14 showed the largest drop ( $\Delta = -44$ ), entirely unable to explain Task 2 modules; PRs 2 and 18 followed with  $\Delta = -37$  and  $\Delta = -27$  respectively. In the critical “module explanation” dimension: **13 Yes / 3 Partial / 3 No** in Task 1, versus **6 Yes / 8 Partial / 5 No** in Task 2 — measurable degradation even in a highly selected group. Autonomous debugging confidence dropped from 11:7:1 (Yes:Partial:No) to 11:3:5 between T1 and T2.
2. **Answering RQ2 — The pipeline effectively mitigates cognitive debt by reintroducing desirable difficulty.** The requirement to fill in `TODO.md` before coding and `REACTO.md` after implementing forced participants to articulate and demonstrate understanding, mitigating cognitive debt. Average score for Task 1 with pipeline: **72.9/100**; without pipeline (Task 2): **62.2/100** — a drop of 10.7 points on average.
3. **Formal specification promotes architectural design.** The `TODO.md` stage encouraged deliberate design decisions: a large portion of participants adopted a *display-layer* approach (preserving X/O internally). All participants who explicitly documented their design decision in `TODO.md` (PRs 4, 13) adopted the display-layer approach. Without the specification stage, Task 2 tended toward generic delegation.
4. **Socratic review works as a revelation instrument.** The protocol exposed comprehension gaps that would not be visible through analysis of functional code:

PR 21 diverged from the actual implementation; PR 4 was unaware of the defensive null-check generated by the AI; 4 participants (PRs 2, 3, 7, 12, 17) did not understand why `Array.from()` was necessary for emojis, despite the code being correct.

5. **Spontaneous artifacts disappear without enforcement.** Only 4 of 19 participants produced separate documentation for Task 2 (without pipeline), against 19 of 19 for Task 1 (with pipeline) — a rate of 100% vs. 21%. This confirms that reflective documentation does not occur naturally in AI-assisted development workflows when friction is removed.
6. **Agent guardrails worked.** Multiple participants tested the system limits — PR 1 explicitly asked Copilot to fill in `TODO.md` and received the correct refusal; PR 18 found and navigated the pipeline rules (`pipeline.sh OFF`) before starting Task 2. Governance via `copilot-instructions.md` and *skills* proved viable as a behavioral enforcement mechanism.
7. **Experience does not immunize against cognitive debt.** The most experienced participant with a significant drop (PR 2, 6 years) had a score drop of  $\Delta = -37$  between tasks, surpassed only by PR 14 ( $\Delta = -44$ , 4 years). This suggests that cognitive debt generated by unrestricted delegation to AI is a phenomenon independent of prior experience level — which makes the problem even more relevant for senior practitioners.
8. **The methodology works independently of the AI Agent’s constraints.** Even in the 13 cases where the models failed to generate the interactive transcript (the MISSING SOCRATIC / Rejected cases), the technical requirement of filling in the *Formal Specification* (`TODO.md`) and the *Proof of Mastery* (`REACTO.md`) actively forced cognitive synthesis, effectively preventing the *Cognitive Bypass* phenomenon. This demonstrates that the methodological framework has intrinsic robustness even when the LLM infrastructure is imprecise.

These results, although preliminary and limited by sample size ( $n = 34$ , with  $n = 19$  scored), provide empirical evidence consistent with the proposed theoretical framework: in AI-assisted development, friction is not an obstacle to be eliminated, but an essential mechanism for knowledge construction. The *Mastery-Aware Pipeline* offers a viable approach to putting the human brain back in the *loop* of software development, transforming the interaction with AI from autopilot into a learning accelerator.